

Government to soon notify city logistics plan: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As the national Capital has emerged as the top in the list of the country's Logistics Ease Across Different States (LEADS) 2025 Index, the Rekha Gupta Government has prepared a city logistics plan, which will soon be notified to boost industrial investment.

Announcing this, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said that under the Prime Minister Gati Shakti Yojana, the Delhi Government has prepared a City Logistics Plan, which has already received approval and will soon be notified.

The objective of this policy is to reduce congestion in freight movement, eliminate

regulatory complexities, and address gaps in logistics infrastructure. "Delhi has secured strong scores in areas such as roads, railways, airports, digital systems, warehousing, and cold storage. The capital has also performed better than the national average in transport services, terminal services, and skilled manpower," she said.

The Chief Minister said this achievement is the result of the Delhi government's continuous efforts to strengthen logistics infrastructure, enhance multimodal connectivity, improve ease of doing business, and promote technology-driven governance. Delhi has shown continuous progress by moving

from the "Achiever" category in LEADS 2023 and 2024 to securing the top position in the country this year.

Under the index, states and union territories are classified into four categories — Exemplary, High Performer, Accelerators, and Growth Seekers — with Exemplary being the highest category.

The Chief Minister informed that the LEADS Index evaluates States and Union Territories on key parameters such as logistics infrastructure, logistics services, regulatory framework, digital integration, sustainability, and stakeholder perception.

The Chief Minister said that under the Prime Minister Gati Shakti Yojana, the Delhi



Government has prepared a City Logistics Plan, which has already received approval and will soon be notified. This will

make urban freight movement, last-mile delivery systems, and urban freight management more stream-

lined and efficient. Out of the 46 mandatory layers on the PM Gati Shakti portal, 38 have already been successfully inte-

grated. In addition, 317 extra layers have also been added. This has strengthened coordinated infrastructure planning and project implementation among various departments.

She said that through the Delhi Single Window System, the process of approvals and permissions related to logistics and industrial investments has been simplified and expedited.

"Under the pothole-free roads campaign undertaken by the Public Works Department, large-scale improvements have been carried out on Delhi's major and internal roads," a statement quoted Gupta as saying.

At the same time, through the Unified Logistics Interface

Platform (ULIP), facilities for API-based real-time monitoring and data exchange have been developed, leading to better coordination among various logistics stakeholders, she added.

The Chief Minister said that the Phase-IV expansion of the Delhi Metro, including the Dwarka Expressway link, has given new momentum to multimodal urban transport in the capital.

"Simultaneously, major economic corridors such as the Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) and the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway are being developed, thereby strengthening freight transportation and regional connectivity," she said.

NDMC vice chairman clarifies Jor Bagh not renamed Anupam Colony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Clarifying that Jor Bagh has not been renamed "Anupam Colony", New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal on Saturday said it is a tag given to colonies achieving high standards of sustainable living.

The clarification came after Shiv Sena UBT leader Priyanka Chaturvedi shared a post on X suggesting that 'flaunting rights' had been taken away from one of Delhi's poshest colonies, before later



acknowledging that she had misunderstood the NDMC's announcement.

Responding to Chaturvedi's post, Chahal said the poster shared by her was "not" announcing a renaming of Jor Bagh to "Anupam Colony" but was simply declaring the locality as an official "Anupam

Colony" under NDMC's sustainability initiative.

"The name hasn't changed. Anupam is merely a certification tag," Chahal said, adding that the formal declaration would take place at Jor Bagh on Sunday, along with a tree-planting drive under the "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" campaign.

He said the "Anupam Colony" initiative is NDMC's model project for decentralised waste management and is aimed at recognising colonies that set benchmarks in waste segregation and sustainable living.

EOW cracks crores worth GST scam, 2 arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A trail of suspicious bank transfers, dummy firms and allegedly forged GST credentials led the Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of Delhi Police to arrest a Delhi-based chartered accountant and a businessman in connection with a GST/VAT fraud case involving transactions worth nearly ₹28.4 crore.

The accused, identified as Rajeev Kumar Parasar and chartered accountant Atul Gupta, were arrested on May 12 in connection with an FIR registered by the EOW in 2020 under charges of cheat-

ing, forgery, impersonation and criminal conspiracy.

According to police, the case came to light after complainant Yashashwee Sharma alleged that the GST/VAT credentials and documents of his firm, M/s Swastik Enterprises, had been fraudulently used without his knowledge to conduct suspicious financial transactions running into crores of rupees.

Police noted that multiple bank accounts linked to firms operating under the name of M/s Swastik Enterprises were used to route and layer large sums of money through a network of



suspected shell entities.

Police said analysis of the accounts showed that money received from various firms was either immediately withdrawn in cash or transferred through RTGS and NEFT to other beneficiary accounts, allegedly to conceal the financial trail.

The EOW said the investi-

gation revealed the role of dummy firms allegedly operated with the assistance of Atul Gupta and another associate, Prakash Gupta, who has since died.

Police alleged that GST returns and statutory compliances for the suspected firms were filed through Gupta's CA firm, M/s Ashok Atul & Co., based in Chandni Chowk.

Officials said the accused allegedly opened and operated bank accounts in the names of dummy proprietors using misused GST and VAT credentials. These accounts were then allegedly used to circulate huge amounts without any corre-

sponding genuine business activity. Police further alleged that GST dues and penalties linked to the suspected firms were deposited through personal accounts of employees and later reimbursed, raising suspicion of efforts to hide the actual beneficiaries of the transactions.

Rajeev Kumar Parasar had remained absconding and untraceable for a considerable period before being tracked down. Following their arrest, both accused were produced before a court, which granted police custody remand for further interrogation and recovery of incriminating evidence.

Proposal Invited from Chartered Accountants/ CA firm for conducting Statutory Audit of Shipra Srishti Apartment Owners Association, 15, Ahinsa Khand-1, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201014 for the Financial Year 2025-26. Interested Chartered Accountants or CA firms may submit their proposals with quotations on or before 22/05/2026 (Friday) at the email add aqa.srishti@gmail.com. Phone: 9953310671. CA/firms must have post qualification experience of more than 5 years. Audit experience of Apartment Association under UP Apartment Act will be preferred. Individual CA's or any CA of firm, should not have any association/ relation with the accountant, internal auditor, AOA board members or any of the Apartment Owner of Shipra Srishti Apartment. Scope of work the Apartment Association is managing the affairs of the common area and facilities of the Multi Story Apartment having 744 flats and the primary source of revenue is the collection of common area monthly maintenance charges from the Apartment Owners. Auditor shall be required to undertake the statutory tax audit of the books of accounts maintained by the board of association. The Audit fee will be minimum Rs. 55,000/- excluding govt. taxes.

Sd/- Secretary

The Pioneer Classified
CHANGE OF NAME

I, HASIN AHMED S/o Mohd. Umar R/o 132, Mannu Ganj, Dehradun, Uttarakhand-248001, have changed my name to HASEEN AHMED for all future purposes vide Affidavit dated 15 May 2026 before Notary Delhi.

PD(1130)C
I SURAJ S/O RAM BAHOR R/O U-1/36 BUDH VIHAR PH-1 SULTANPURI DELHI-110086 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SURAJ PASI

PD(1331)C
I Anil Kumar Tomar S/o Sh. Vijay Pal Singh R/o M-86, Lane No. 05, 1st Floor, Shastri Nagar, Delhi-110052, declare that I have changed my name from ANIL KUMAR to ANIL KUMAR TOMAR for all purposes in future.

PD(1332)C
I, hitherto known as SUNITA W/o Pankaj Manchanda R/o House No. C-66 Gali No 1, Bhajanpura North East, Delhi - 110053, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SUNITA MANCHANDA.

PD(1337)C
I, HEMANT BHARDWAJ S/o Shri Rakesh Kumar Bhardwaj R/o 1/5349, Gali No. 14, Balbir Nagar Extn., Shahdara Delhi-110032 declared that HEMANT & HEMANT BHARDWAJ is same person for all purposes.

PD(1338)C

Protest at Jantar Mantar condemns violence against Kuki-Zo community

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Kuki Students' Organisation on Saturday held a protest demonstration at Jantar Mantar here against the alleged violence, abductions and killings targeting the Kuki-Zo community in Manipur and other parts of the Northeast, according to a statement issued here.

The Delhi-NCR unit of the



organisation alleged that members of the Kuki-Zo community were being targeted by cadres of the National Socialist Council of

Nagaland Isak-Muivah (NSCN-IM) and its "proxy groups", and accused the authorities of failing to take decisive action despite

repeated incidents of violence. The protest was held following the killing of three Kuki-Zo church pastors on May 13, injuries to several others and the alleged abduction of 14 Kuki-Zo men, the statement said.

Students who gathered at the protest were seen holding placards reading: "Kidnapping civilians is a war crime", "Justice before peace", "Stop ethnic violence."

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (ROADS), PUBLIC WORKS ROADS DEPARTMENT, ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-03

No. CE/DEV/TB/57/2025-26 /II

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDER (RE-BID)

The Chief Engineer (Roads), PWRD, Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 invites Bid on behalf of Governor of Assam for 1 (One) no. of package for Improvement of Roads under SOPD-G for the year 2025-26 in Goalpara District of Assam amounting to Rs. 409.06 Lakh (approx.) including GST etc. from approved & eligible Contractors registered with PWRD, Assam.

Details may be seen from 18.05-2026 at website www.assamtenders.gov.in. Amendment /Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Roads), PWRD, Assam, Chandmari Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/52/17-May-26

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is hereby informed that my clients Sh. Ajeet Singh S/o Sh. Lal Chand and his wife Smt. Manju both Resident of Village Madanpur Dabas, Delhi-110081 have severed all their relations with their son namely Mohit Dabas and his wife Smt. Moni and also debarred them from their all movable and immovable properties.

Dirender Mathur (Advocate)
Ch.No. 1032, Rohini District, Delhi-110085

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Ajay Kumar S/o Sh. Mangoolal, R/o 29/500/19A, 1C, Block-29, Vishwas Nagar, Gali No. 10, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, hereby declare that due to the misconduct of my son Mr. Anmol Goel, I have severed all relations with him and debarred him from all my movable and immovable properties. I shall not be responsible for any of his acts or liabilities henceforth.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD
CHARAIDEO DISTRICT TERRITORIAL BUILDING DIVISION, SONARI

BD/TF (N) / PI II/2026/122

TENDER NOTICE

The Executive Engineer, PWD Charaideo District Territorial Building Division invites bids, on behalf of the Governor of Assam, with approximate bid price of Rs 34,95,213 Lakh (Rupees Thirty Four Lakh Ninety Five Thousand Two Hundred Thirteen) only for the work "Construction of Market Shed at Nagahat Weekly Market" under Charaideo District Territorial Building from eligible contractor registered with PWD (Building), Assam. Details may be seen at website <https://www.assamtenders.gov.in> and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours.

The bidding documents are available online on <https://www.assamtenders.gov.in> from 20/05/2026 to 09/06/2026. The Bidders must be registered with the E- tendering system (ETS) of the Govt. of Assam (<https://www.assamtenders.gov.in>). Bids must be submitted online on <https://www.assamtenders.gov.in> on or before 14:00 Hours on 09/06/2026. Other details can be seen in the bidding document.

Sd/-
Executive Engineer, PWD
Charaideo District Territorial Building Division
Sonari, Assam

DIPR/C/PIO/54/17-May-26

AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samarthswar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006 Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

Publication of Notice regarding possession of property u/s 13(4) of SARFAESI Act 2002 Notice is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated hereinafter calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said Act on the dates mentioned against each account. The Borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd for an amount and interest thereon. The borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets

Name of Borrower/ Co-borrower: Mr. Mohan Goel House No-22-A/6, Upper Ground Floor, Shakti Nagar, New Delhi 110007, mailing, Permanent & Property Address Also At: Mr. Mohan Goel 1167/ 1072/ A-8, First Floor, Kucha Mahajan, Chandni Chowk, New Delhi-110006 Office Address Also At: Mrs. Neetu Goel House No-22-A/6, Upper Ground Floor, Shakti Nagar, New Delhi 110007. Co Borrower Description of Property : Entire Ground Floor of Built Up Property Bearing No. 22-A/6, Two Side Open Without its Terrace/roof Rights, Situated In The Layout Plan Of Roshanara Extension Scheme, Presently known As Shakti Nagar, Delhi-110007 And Bounded As Under- East - As Per Title Deed, West - As Per Title Deed, North - As Per Title Deed, South - As Per Title Deed

Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice:
19-Feb-2026	13-May-2026	Nine Lakh Five Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty Nine only

Name of Borrower/ Co-borrower: Late Mr. Pramod Bhatnagar R/o House No. 698, Sector-31 32A urban Estate, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001 2. Mr. Pranav Bhatnagar Son of the Deceased Borrower/ S/o Late. Mr. Pramod Bhatnagar R/o House No. 698, Sector-31 32A urban Estate, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001 Description of Property : House No. 698, Sector-31 32a, Urban Estate, Gurgaon, Haryana-and Bounded As Under- East - As Per Title Deed, West - As Per Title Deed, North - As Per Title Deed, South - As Per Title Deed

Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice:
03-Feb-2026	13-May-2026	Sixty Six Lakh Seventy Seven Thousand Two Hundred Sixty Three and Ninety Five Paisa Only

Name of Borrower/ Co-borrower: 1. Sunil Kumar S/o Prem Prakash R/o A-8,S/F, Golden Park, Shivpuri, Krishna Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi-110051 Also At: Sunil Kumar (Proprietor) Arola Enterprises A-21, G/F, Gali No-3, Jagatpuri, Near Reliance Comm., Delhi-110051 2. Mrs. Pooja Rani D/o Mr. Jessa Ram R/o A-8, U/GF, Golden Park, Shivpuri, Krishna Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi-110051 Description of Property : A-8 (Old No. 21), Upper Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Out of Kharsa No. 10/92, Situated in the layout plan of Golden Park, Shiv Puri in the area of Village Khureji Khars, Shahdara, New Delhi East : As Per Title Deed, West : As Per Title Deed, North : As Per Title Deed, South:As Per Title Deed

Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice:
22-Jan-2026	13-May-2025	Six Lakh Forty One Thousand Five Hundred Fifty Five and Fifty Three Paisa Only

Name of Borrower/ Co-borrower: 1. Mrs. Priti Devi R/o Flat No. 102 Tower- Vipul Green Sec 48 Gurgaon Haryana Also At: Priti Devi R/o Unit No. 202, 2nd Floor Tower As Avalon Rosewood Bhivadi Raj 2. Mr. Naveen Mahiwal R/o Flat No. 102 Tower- Vipul Green Sec 48 Gurgaon Haryana Description of Property : All That Part And Partial Of Unit No. 202, 2nd Floor Tower As Avalon Rosewood Bhivadi Raj And Bounded As Under - East: As Per Site Plan, West: As Per Site Plan, North: As Per Site Plan, South: As Per Site Plan

Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice:
08-Dec-2025	13-May-2026	Lakh Fifty One Thousand Five Hundred Fifty Three Only

Place: Noida, Date: 17.05.2026

-SD/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samarthswar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006 Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

APPENDIX IV (Refer Rule – 8(1)) POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice dated 04th-Feb-2026 calling M/s. Sagar Motor Co. Mr. Rajeev Sagar, Mr. Naval Kishore & Mr. Sanjeev Sagar (Borrower/ Co Borrower/ Mortgagee/ Guarantor) to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being arising from the various documents executed by you, we hereby call upon you to make payment of an of Rs. 47,85,753.29 (Rupees Forty Seven Lakhs Eighty Five Thousand Seven Hundred Fifty Three and Twenty Nine Paisa only) due as on 17.12.2025 together with interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/ Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on 14.05.2026. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower (s)/ Mortgagee(s)/ Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount of Rs. 47,85,753.29 (Rupees Forty Seven Lakhs Eighty Five Thousand Seven Hundred Fifty Three and Twenty Nine Paisa only) due as on 17.12.2025 together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment & expenses thereon. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s)'s attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY:

Property No.1: All That Piece And Parcel Of Land Property Booth No. 249, Area Measuring 22.68 Sq. Mtrs., Situated In The Residential Colony Known As Sector-jail Land, Urban Estate At Telsai & Distt. Gurgaon, Haryana -122001 Together With All The Buildings And Structures Thereon, Fixtures, Fittings And All Plant And Machinery Attached To The Earth Or Permanently Fastened To Anything Attached To The Earth, Both Present And Future. East-Corridor, West-Open, South- Property No. 248, North – Property No. 250

Property No.2 : All That Piece And Parcel Of Land Property Booth No. 250, Area Measuring 22.68 Sq. Mtrs., Situated In The Residential Colony Known As Sector-jail Land, Urban Estate At Telsai & Distt. Gurgaon, Haryana -122001 Together With All The Buildings And Structures Thereon, Fixtures, Fittings And All Plant And Machinery Attached To The Earth Or Permanently Fastened To Anything Attached To The Earth, Both Present And Future. East-Booth No. 251(S-E), West- Booth No. 249 (NW), South – Open (S-W), North -Road Corridor (N-E)

Please Note That As Mention In Sub Section 13 Of Section 13 Of The Aforesaid Act, You Shall Not Transfer By Way Of Sale, Lease Or Otherwise Any Of The Assets Stated Under Security Refered To In This Notice Without Priorwritten Consent Of Our Bank.

Dated: 17.05.2026, Place: Gurgaon

Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

Police bust extortion racket, 4 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have busted a honey-trap and extortion racket in which gang members allegedly posed as police officers and extorted money from victims using dating applications.

According to police, the four persons arrested are Sushil Kumar (53) of Najafgarh, Deepak, alias Sajjan, from Sonipat, Haryana, Vinod Pandit (57) of Uttam Nagar, and Neeraj Tyagi, alias Dhiru (44) of Tila.

According to police, after the case was registered at the Crime Branch, it developed intelligence on the gang activities, and a trap was laid near Kalyan Jewellers in



Rajouri Garden on May 12.

"During the operation, police intercepted a suspicious vehicle. While three accused managed to flee, Sushil Kumar was apprehended on the spot along with the victim. Kumar was allegedly wearing a fake police uniform at the time," a senior police officer said.

Based on the victim's complaint and investigation, the remaining accused were later arrested.

Police said the gang created fake female profiles on dating applications to lure unsuspecting men. After establishing contact, female associates would invite the victims to meet at public places before taking them to rented flats or isolated locations, police said.

"Other gang members would then conduct fake police raids and threaten the victims with false criminal cases, including rape allegations, to extort money," the officer said.

The complainant told police that he met a woman through a dating app and was later threatened by four men, including one in a fake police uniform, who demanded ₹15 lakh.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD
CHARAIDEO DISTRICT TERRITORIAL BUILDING DIVISION, SONARI

No. CDTBD/TF(N)/P-II/2026/124

TENDER NOTICE

The Executive Engineer, PWD Charaideo District Territorial Building Division invites bids, on behalf of the Governor of Assam, with approximate bid price of Rs 23,58,800 Lakh (Rupees .) only for the work Twenty Three Lakh Fifty Eight Thousand Eight Hundred "Repairing/Renovation of the District & Sessions Judge office at Sonari, Charaideo under Charaideo District Territorial Building from eligible contractor registered with PWD (Building), Assam. Details may be seen at website <https://www.assamtenders.gov.in> and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours.

The bidding documents are available online on <https://www.assamtenders.gov.in> from 20/05/2026 to 09/06/2026. The Bidders must be registered with the E- tendering system (ETS) of the Govt. of Assam (<https://www.assamtenders.gov.in>). Bids must be submitted online on <https://www.assamtenders.gov.in> on or before 14:00 Hours on 09/06/2026. Other details can be seen in the bidding document.

Sd/-
Executive Engineer, PWD
Charaideo District Territorial Building Division
Sonari, Assam

DIPR/C/PIO/51/17-May-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE COMMISSIONER OF TRANSPORT ASSAM
PARIBAHAN BHAWAN JAWAHAR NAGAR KHANAPARA GUWAHATI-22
PH No. 0361-2304110(0):: E-mail-comtransport.assam@gov.in
Website-www.comtransport.gov.in

No. CT/E-432115/3386

CORRIGENDUM

This is Pertaining to the EOI released by the Office of the Commissioner of Transport, Assam vide order No.E/432115/2079, dated 13th March 2026 and No.E/432115/3189, dated 5th May, 2026 for 'Request for EDI from Manufacturers of Vehicle Location Tracking Devices (VLTD) for fitment to Public Transport Vehicles in Assam'

This office hereby issues the following corrigendum to the EOI.

Amendments / Corrections / Clarifications

Sl. NO.	Clause / Section	Amended / Clarified Text
1	Clause 10.21 (Pg 26), Clause 12.1.1 (Pg 28), Annexure U - Point 2(e) (Pg 42)	The amount of ₹30 Lakhs serves as the mandatory minim threshold for initial panelment. To accommodate market scaling, the PBG requirement follows a tiered structure: an incremental security of ₹ 30 Lakhs for the base slab, supplemented by an additional ₹10 Lakhs for the 3,000-10,000 device bracket, and a further ₹10 Lakhs for the 10,000-20,000 bracket, continuing @Rs.10,00,000/- per 10000 devices progressively for all future additions. The PBG need to be submitted post-emanpanelment.
2	Clause 3.5 (Pg 20)	The word "DTO Offices" may be read as " DTO jurisdiction"
3	Annexure -VIII (Page 52)	The word "DoT" may be read as "Department of Transport71 Transport Department, Assam"
4	Clause 10.4 (Pg -24)	The words "four (3)", "last four years" & "all four years" may be read as "three (3)", "last three years" & "all three years" respectively.
5	Clause 15.7 (Pg -31)	The following items stands deleted from this list - • PCB serial number (Printed Circuit Board) • Firmware version and checksum (Hash) • Device Public Key

All other terms and conditions of the EOI document shall remain the same.

Sd/-
Commissioner of Transport
Assam, Guwahati-22

DIPR/C/PIO/53/17-May-26

Govt slashes VAT on aviation turbine fuel from 25% to 7%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Rekha Gupta Government on Saturday decided to reduce the Value Added Tax (VAT) on Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) from 25 per cent to 7 per cent. According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the decision to reduce VAT on ATF was taken at the Cabinet meeting. "Delhi Government has decided to reduce the value-added tax (VAT) on aviation turbine fuel (ATF) from the existing 25 per cent to 7 per cent, a move which is likely to benefit the airlines and common passengers," the official statement said.

This comes a day after Maharashtra reduced Value Added Tax (VAT) on Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) to 7 per cent from 18 per cent for six months, effective May 15, to ease fuel costs for airlines amid high global crude prices and West Asia-related disruptions. The chief minister said the concessional rate will initially remain in force for a period of six months. The decision, taken in the interest of both the nation and Delhi, may result in an estimated revenue loss of nearly ₹985 crore for the Government. Sharing details of the Cabinet decision, the Chief Minister said that although the GST regime has been in

force across the country since 2017, States still retain the authority to levy VAT on six petroleum products listed under the State List of the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution, including Aviation Turbine Fuel. This is the reason why ATF continues to remain outside the purview of GST. The Chief Minister informed that airlines pay VAT and central excise duty on ATF while purchasing fuel from oil companies. VAT on ATF, which is levied by state governments, remains a significant cost component and varies widely across states. ATF, which accounts for nearly 30-40 per cent of



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurates the construction work of 25 main roads in Shastri Nagar PIONEER PHOTO

airline operating costs, has come under sustained price pressure due to geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions, and volatility in global

crude oil markets, particularly amid Middle East conflicts and periodic airspace restrictions. The elevated fuel costs have significantly impacted

airline balance sheets, forcing carriers to adjust fares, especially on high-demand domestic routes. She further stated that VAT on ATF is estimated to generate annual revenue of around ₹1,368 crore, accounting for nearly 19 per cent of the Delhi Government's total annual VAT collection. As a result, VAT on ATF continues to remain a significant source of revenue for the Delhi Government. The chief minister also clarified that Delhi Airport currently remains the country's largest aviation hub. During 2024-25, nearly 8 crore passengers were recorded at the Indira Gandhi International Airport, the

highest in the country. She said that the Delhi Government remains committed to promoting aviation, tourism, trade, logistics, and investment and is continuously working to maintain the national capital as the country's strongest economic and connectivity centre. The Chief Minister reiterated that the Government's decision will remain in force for six months for the time being. On Friday, Maharashtra reduced the VAT on ATF from 18 per cent to 7 per cent, a move expected to provide relief to airlines and passengers amid rising operational costs due to the

ongoing West Asia crisis. Union Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu thanked Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis for the "timely intervention," noting that the decision would help keep airfares in check at a time when global challenges are pushing costs upwards. The Indian aviation sector has been grappling with airspace closures, uncertain operations and a sharp spike in ATF prices following the escalation of tensions in West Asia. ATF typically accounts for 30-40 per cent of an airline's operating costs, making it one of the largest expense heads for carriers.

DU begins registrations for PG admissions 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The University of Delhi has started registrations for admission to its two-year postgraduate programmes for the 2026-27 academic session, according to an official statement on Saturday. The application process will continue from May 16 to June 7, the university said, adding that admissions to the programmes will be conducted through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal based solely on Common University Entrance Test (CUET-PG) 2026 scores in the relevant test papers. The university has also introduced an auto-integration system this year to fetch candidates' details and CUET scores directly through DigitLocker and API Setu. The integration would provide a uniform authentication mechanism for government services under the Digital India initiative while strengthening data security



and reducing duplication, it said, adding that the step would also strengthen security. According to the notification, students currently studying in the third or fourth year of their undergraduate courses will be eligible to apply for the two-year master's degree programmes, subject to the fulfilment of programme-specific eligibility criteria. The university said that from the 2026-27 academic session onwards, it will offer two categories of postgraduate programmes in line with the National Education Policy

(NEP) framework, one-year master's programmes and two-year master's degree programmes. The registration fee for SC, ST and PwBD candidates has been fixed at Rs 100 per programme, and for UR, OBC-NCL and EWS categories, it is Rs 250 per programme. The notification further advised candidates to refer to the PG bulletin of information and the CSAS-PG, 2026 guidelines for minimum eligibility, programme-specific eligibility, and allocation rules. DU said applications for one-year postgraduate pro-

grammes under the NEP would be invited separately through another portal to be announced later. Students pursuing four-year bachelor's honours degrees with research or entrepreneurship, and those completing four-year bachelor's degrees with a major in the subject concerned, will be eligible for these programmes, subject to the fulfilment of other conditions, it added. The university also announced provisions for "mid-entry" and spot admission rounds for candidates who miss the initial application window. According to the university, "Candidates who failed to apply for CSAS(PG)-2026 within the stipulated time and are desirous of participating in CSAS(PG)-2026 can participate through the Mid-Entry window, by paying a Mid-Entry fee of ₹1,000 (non-refundable)." The university also advised candidates to visit the admission website regularly.

2008 judgement in focus as DU, St Stephen's College clash over principal's appointment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Even as a fresh tussle brews between Delhi University and St Stephen's College over the appointment of the college principal, a 2008 court judgement has brought renewed focus on the provisions given to minority institutions in choosing their heads. The ruling, delivered in a dispute similar to the present one at the time of the appointment of Valson Thampu as the principal, had held that St Stephen's College, being a minority institution, was not bound by provisions of the DU ordinance relating to the constitution of selection committees for appointing principals. The judgement has gained significance after the university recently asked the college not to proceed with the appointment of Susan Elias as the new principal, saying the



selection committee was not constituted in accordance with the University Grants Commission regulations. "In the result, the petition succeeds. It is declared that Clause 7(2) of Ordinance XVIII of Delhi University does not apply to the petitioner, which is a minority institution. The petitioner is directed to proceed with the selection process for filling up the post of Principal, which is vacant since January 2007, and fill up the post of Principal within eight weeks from today," the judgement had said.

In its ruling delivered on August 21, 2008, the Delhi High Court had declared that the clause of the Delhi University, which prescribed the composition and procedure of the selection committee for appointment of principals, would not apply to St Stephen's College. The division bench had further held that the right to appoint a principal is a key facet of the constitutional right of minority institutions to administer educational institutions under Article 30(1) of the Constitution.

Advocate Romy Chacko, who had argued for the college in the case, said, "The letter sent by the registrar to the college holds no merit, as had been highlighted by the court in a very similar case in 2008. The court had observed that as a minority institution, the college could appoint its own head, as long as qualifications were met." Chacko is also representing the college in a separate case between the college and the university regarding the last principal, John Varghese's term extension. Aman Kumar, an elected EC member of DU and a part of the committee, said, "We will be asking the college to send all the related information of the appointed teachers, along with their API scores, so it can be properly investigated. It is indeed a minority college, but at the same time, the rules need to be followed."

US national arrested at Delhi Airport with 115 gold bars hidden in belt



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Customs officials arrested a US national of Indian origin at the Indira Gandhi International Airport after allegedly seizing 115 gold bars weighing over 3.5 kg. The gold was concealed inside a specially designed belt and hidden pockets stitched into his trousers. The passenger had arrived from San Francisco on an Air India flight and was intercepted by the Air Intelligence Unit (AIU) of Customs after officers developed specific intelligence based on risk profiling of passengers, according to a press statement issued by the department on 15 May 2026. Officials said the accused attempted to cross the Green Channel "covertly" at the international arrivals terminal before they stopped him for inspection. During a personal search carried out in the presence of independent witnesses, customs officers recovered 115 gold bars of 24-karat purity

allegedly concealed in the inner pockets of his trousers and in a specially modified belt. The seized gold weighed 3,565 grams and was confiscated under Section 110 of the Customs Act, 1962. The passenger was arrested under Section 104 of the Act, and further investigation is underway, officials said. Customs officials said the seizure comes amid a recent spike in attempts to smuggle gold into the country following the increase in customs duty on the precious metal from 6 per cent to 15 per cent. According to officials, the higher duty has sharply increased profit margins for smuggling syndicates, leading to the use of increasingly sophisticated concealment techniques. Officials added that enforcement agencies have intensified surveillance at airports by deploying real-time passenger data analytics, advanced risk-profiling tools, and stricter physical screening measures to counter evolving smuggling methods.

EOW busts ₹128 crore GST fraud racket

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police's Economic Offences Wing (EOW) has busted an alleged GST fraud cartel operating through shell companies and fake invoicing networks, arresting six individuals involved in swindling ₹128 crore, an official said on Saturday. The accused allegedly operated fake firms, generating bogus GST invoices, and availing wrongful Input Tax Credit (ITC) without any actual supply of goods or services, EOW said in a statement. On May 15, EOW teams made several raids at different locations in Delhi-NCR and arrested Raj Kumar Dixit, Amar Kumar, Vibhash Kumar Mitra, Nitin Verma, Mohammad Waseem, and Abid. A case of GST fraud was registered against a fake firm, M/s RK Enterprises, at the EOW Police Station on March 24 under various sections of the BNS. The complainant alleged that his Aadhaar card, PAN card, electricity bill and bio-



metric details were misused on the pretext of providing him employment in the GST Department, the statement read. During the investigation, the police found that the firm had been created in September 2025 without the victim's knowledge and was subsequently used for transactions exceeding ₹128 crore. "Wrongful ITC amounting to nearly ₹10 crore was fraudulently availed through the fake entity," read the statement. The probe, involving technical surveillance, analysis of GST records, banking transactions, email IDs and other digital evidence, revealed that Dixit and

Dilip Kumar, still at large, were the main conspirators behind the racket. The police said Dixit operated a large-scale fake invoicing syndicate from Daryaganj with his brothers and associates and orchestrated the creation of nearly 250 shell companies using forged and fraudulent documents. Investigators said the accused used these firms for bogus billing, fake GST transactions, and fraudulent ITC claims while concealing the financial trail through multiple bank accounts, mobile numbers and intermediaries. Amar Kumar and Vibhash Kumar Mitra facilitated the formation of shell firms and bogus GST activities, they said. Nitin Verma allegedly created and operated multiple fake firms with the help of accountants, while Mohammad Waseem and Abid were involved in providing bank accounts and internet banking credentials for routing fake transactions and proceeds generated through bogus GST activities.

City voters will have option to submit enumeration forms online

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Under the mega SIR exercise for verification of Delhi's electoral rolls, beginning with door-to-door visits by booth-level officers (BLOs) from June 30, the voters will have the option to submit their enumeration forms online. Political parties in Delhi have also intensified preparations for the special intensive revision (SIR), intensifying training of their booth-

level agents (BLAs) across over 13,000 polling booths in the city. Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) office said the main objective of the SIR is "no eligible citizen is left out while no ineligible person is included in the electoral roll". The exercise will cover all voters aged 18 years and above by the qualifying date, which is October 1. During SIR, over 13,000 BLOs will conduct house-to-house enumeration. Every existing elector, whose name



exists in the electoral roll will be provided an enumeration form (in duplicate) to be

filled by them and return one copy to the BLOs, said a Delhi CEO office statement.

Provision will also be given to electors to fill out the enumeration form online during the SIR period, said the CEO's office. The voter list of SIR, held in 2002 in Delhi, has been uploaded to the website of the CEO, Delhi. Voters who have shifted in Delhi from other states after 2002 can find their names on the Election Commission of India (ECI) portal. Door-to-door visits by BLOs will start from June 30 and conclude on July 29, after

which the draft electoral roll will be published on August 5. The final electoral roll after SIR will be published on October 7. The voters who are permanently staying in Delhi prior to 2002 can check their names in the voter list of 2002 and note down their details. The CEO office said that voters who moved to Delhi from other states after 2002 will not find their names in Delhi's 2002 voter list.

PWD Minister kicks off major upgrade for Narela-Bawana road

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, on Saturday, kick-started a major upgrade for the Narela-Bawana road, launching work on a precast RCC drain stretching from the Narela railway crossing to the DJB outfall. Covering 9.5 km in total, 5 km on one side and 4.5 km on the other, the ₹55 crore project is a key piece of

Delhi's master plan to tackle waterlogging with a lasting, well-structured fix. "Precast technology allows us to build faster, with higher quality and less disruption. Our focus is on durable solutions and delivering tangible improvements for residents," said Parvesh Sahib Singh. The drain will be built using cutting-edge precast technology, in which each component is crafted in a



controlled setting before being assembled on site. This method speeds up con-

struction and ensures top-notch quality, strength, and consistency.

GOVT ISSUES SOP TO ENSURE CONTINUOUS MONITORING OF DEWATERING PUMPS

New Delhi: The Delhi Government has issued a detailed Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) to ensure continuous monitoring of dewatering pumps to avoid waterlogging during monsoon. The 10-point SOP issued by the Public Works Department (PWD) has listed out measures to be taken for traffic management, dewatering exercise, prevent damage to roads and ensure public safety during the monsoon season in the city.

According to the order, pumps will be "operated on auto mode wherever automation has been done and continuous monitoring of operations must be carried out to check for vibration, overheating, unusual noise, or leakage".



RITES LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Shikhar, Plot No.1, Sector-29, Gurugram - 122001
CIN No: L74899DL1974GOI007227

Requirement of professionals for the following post(s) / discipline(s) through interview at RITES Office.

VC No(s).	Individual Consultant Post(s)	No. of Posts	Payment for Services (in Rs. P.M.)	Mode & Venue of Selection process
YP/39-58/26	For various posts under Civil / Mining / IT / Electrical / Instrumentation / Mechanical / etc. disciplines. Location - Aizawl, Mizoram	23	20,000/- to 2,00,000/-	RITES Corporate Office Gurugram (or) RITES Guwahati Office (or) Video conferencing

For details regarding application, T&Cs, etc, candidates may see the detailed advertisement posted on RITES website www.rites.com under Career Section.



IN FOCUS



Commando performing during an event at Gandhi Maidan in Patna

PTI

Kerala: UDF races to finalise Cabinet in last-minute talks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Kerala capital witnessed hectic political activity on Saturday as UDF leaders held a series of meetings to finalise ministerial berths and decide nominees for the new ministry headed by CM-designate VD Satheesan, which will assume office on May 18.

Senior leaders of the Congress and its alliance partners remained engaged in back-to-back discussions from the morning at the Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee headquarters and other venues in the capital city.

The talks focused on the allocation of portfolios, representation for alliance part-



Congress MP KC Venugopal during a meeting with Kerala CM-designate VD Satheesan at the former's residence in New Delhi

PTI

ners, and balancing regional and community interests in the new Cabinet.

Meetings among Congress leaders were held under the leadership of Satheesan, KPCC president Sunny Joseph, and Deepa Dasmunsi, who arrived in

the state following directions from the All India Congress Committee to oversee the discussions.

By evening, the negotiations had reportedly entered a more sensitive phase as leaders worked to resolve differences over key portfo-

lios and the final composition of the ministry. Sources said the Congress leadership was making urgent efforts to release the final list of ministers at the earliest after completing discussions with alliance partners. Separate meetings were also held by constituent parties of the UDF to decide their representatives in the ministry.

Parties consulted senior members and legislators before forwarding their final recommendations to the Congress leadership. Political observers described the atmosphere in the capital as intense, with senior leaders moving between meetings throughout the day amid mounting speculation over who would secure important Cabinet positions.

Eight Naxals held in Maharashtra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gadchiroli

Five Naxal functionaries with a total bounty of ₹38 lakh on their heads surrendered in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli district, a police official said on Saturday.

Police also said eight Maoists from Maharashtra, Telangana and Chhattisgarh were arrested during a series of intelligence-based operations conducted jointly with the Central Reserve Police Force.

The eight Maoists were arrested in operations carried out under the leadership of Superintendent of Police M Ramesh. "On May 13, police teams nabbed four Maoists, identified as Jayaram Monge Gawade, Mukesh alias Lachhu Avalam, Vijay alias Mangadu Hunga Tamo and Rajita. Subsequent search opera-



tions in forest areas led to the seizure of rifles, ammunition and Maoist literature, he added.

On May 14, in operations in Kumnar and Naitala villages, police nabbed senior Maoist leaders Raju alias Mangadu Weko, Janni alias Nagi Yemla, Jyoti alias Akila Potavi and Amti alias Ayati Podiyam and seized large quantities of arms, including AK-47 rifles, SLRs, INSAS rifles, BGL launchers and hundreds of live cartridges, the official said.

Brahmins remark: Fresh FIR filed against SP's Bhati

PIONEER NEWS SERVCICE
■ Baghpat

Samajwadi Party spokesperson Rajkumar Bhati has been booked in another case over his alleged objectionable remarks against the Brahmin community, with the latest FIR registered in Uttar Pradesh's Baghpat district, police said on Friday.

The FIR was registered at the Baghpat Kotwali police station on the basis of a complaint filed by former district president of the Akhil Bharatiya Brahmin Mahasabha, Yogesh Sharma, they said. Earlier, the police in Ghaziabad, Noida and Sultanpur had also lodged FIRs on similar charges against Bhati, who has said he was taken out of context on the basis of a video clip from his longer statement made during an event.

Baghpat Kotwali SHO Brijesh Kumar said the case was registered under sections 196 (promoting enmity between different groups) and 299 (deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). He said the complaint referred to a viral video in which Bhati allegedly made objectionable remarks.

"The viral video and other facts are being examined. Further action will be taken as per rules after the investi-



gation," the SHO said. Meanwhile, members of the Rashtravadi Brahmin Mahasangh staged a protest at the tehsil premises on Friday and submitted a memorandum addressed to the President through the subdivisional magistrate, demanding Bhati's expulsion from the party and strict action against him.

District president of the organisation Acharya Praveen Pulastya alleged that the SP spokesperson used insulting language against the Brahmin community on social media, triggering anger among community members.

According to locals, a video purportedly showing Bhati making controversial remarks about the Brahmin community has gone viral on social media. Following the circulation of the video, protests have been held at various places and memoranda submitted to the administration.

Jarange warns fresh agitation from May 30 over Maratha quota

PIONEER NEWS SERVCICE
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange on Saturday announced an indefinite hunger strike from May 30 over the community's "unfulfilled" demands, and gave the Maharashtra Government a deadline of May 29 to distribute Kunbi caste certificates in Marathwada.

Speaking to reporters in Antarwali Sarati village, Jalna district, Jarange demanded the dissolution of the Maratha quota subcommittee, claiming the panel has done nothing for the community, while pressing for a separate ministry for the Maratha and Kunbi communities. State minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, who



heads the panel, said he was not keen on clinging to the post if his resignation could help resolve the reservation issue and satisfy the agitators.

Jarange claimed that the state Government has completely halted

the process of issuing Kunbi caste certificates to Marathas. "Earlier, we used to get caste certificates, but now they have stopped disbursement. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has stopped the process. When we asked for certificates according to the Hyderabad gazette, we got a few, but now officials tell us they have been instructed by the Government not to issue them," he alleged.

He further demanded that the State Government immediately implement the Satara, Aurang and other gazettes, validate already issued caste certificates, and drop police cases registered against Maratha protesters during previous agitations. "The Government has not implemented the Satara

gazette even eight months after its announcement. We cannot give them more time," he said, giving the Government a deadline of May 29 to distribute Kunbi certificates or face agitation from May 30.

Jarange has been demanding that all Marathas be recognised as Kunbis, an agrarian caste included in the OBC category, which will make them eligible for reservation in Government jobs and education.

He further urged community experts and scholars to gather at Antarwali Sarati, about 400 km from Mumbai, on May 28 to discuss the state Government's recent policy that bars reserved category candidates from claiming open category seats.

The state cabinet, earlier this

week, approved a policy that candidates from reserved categories who avail concessions in competitive examinations, such as age relaxation and educational qualification, will not be eligible to claim appointment against open category posts.

"The Government came out with a GR two days back that OBCs cannot claim seats from the open category. Had this decision been taken earlier, the OBC category would not have eaten into our seats. The Government has taken the decision now after they (OBCs) have taken our seats," he said.

Jarange further claimed that financial assistance schemes for the Maratha community are being intentionally stalled.

Woman jumps into canal with two daughters in Dehradun; children safe

PIONEER NEWS SERVCICE
■ Dehradun

A 28-year-old woman, along with her two daughters, allegedly jumped into the Shakti Canal in the Vikasnagar area here on Saturday, police said.

They added that bystanders, stunned by the incident, managed to safely rescue her daughters, three-year-old Aarvi and another three-month-old infant.

The police reported that at around 4.30 PM, near Bridge Number 1, Kiran Chandel, a resident of Mandi Chowk in Vikasnagar,



jumped into the canal with her two daughters.

Upon receiving the information, the police arrived at the scene and launched a search operation to locate the woman with the assistance of the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF).

However, she has not yet been found. Both children have been sent to a nearby

hospital for medical treatment. According to information obtained from the woman's family members, the police stated that Kiran had entered into a love marriage with Dheeraj Chandel in 2020. Dheeraj works in Hyderabad but has been home on leave since May 10. However, he was not present at the house on Saturday.

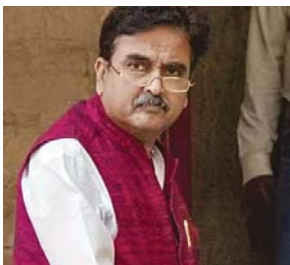
Vivek Kutiyal, the Circle Officer (CO) of Vikasnagar, stated that an investigation is underway to determine the reasons behind the woman jumping into the canal with her children.

RG Kar case: BJP MP alleges lapses in CBI inquiry, seeks probe into officer's role

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

BJP MP and former Calcutta High Court judge Abhijit Ganguly on Saturday alleged lapses in the CBI probe into the rape and murder of the post-graduate trainee doctor at RG Kar hospital, and demanded an investigation into the role of a senior agency officer – Seema Pahuja – who had supervised the inquiry.

After visiting the state-run hospital, Ganguly claimed that certain crucial aspects linked to the case had not been examined by the CBI.



"I came here after learning that Pahuja, the CBI officer who was in charge of the investigation, did not carry out two very important tasks," he told reporters after visiting the hospital. Ganguly alleged that a room in the hospital premises, which has remained locked

and sealed for nearly two years and could potentially contain incriminating material, had not been opened during the investigation. "I came personally to check whether such a room actually exists. I saw that it is still locked and sealed," he said.

The BJP MP also referred to a staircase inside the hospital building which, according to him, was allegedly used to move the body from the original scene of crime on the night the doctor was murdered, and placed in the seminar room of the chest medicine department where it was eventually discovered.

Farmers' land being grabbed for profiteering in Bidadi Township project, claims Deve Gowda

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Former Prime Minister HD Deve Gowda on Saturday alleged that farmers' lands are being grabbed for profiteering in the name of the 'Bidadi Township' project.

He also announced that he would launch a fight against it. The JD(S) patriarch repeatedly targeted Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, who is also the Minister for Bengaluru Development, without naming him. He was referring to the ₹18,133 crore Greater Bengaluru Integrated Suburban Project at Bidadi in Bengaluru South



Former prime minister and JD(S) chief HD Deve Gowda addressing a press conference in Bengaluru, Karnataka

AP

district, which was approved in the April 30 Cabinet meeting. The project will cover about 7,481 acres across nine villages in

Bengaluru South district and Ramanagara taluk.

A section of farmers and local villagers have opposed the project and are protesting

against the land acquisition.

"This Government is trying to grab farmers' lands for business interests. One person has said, 'If farmers beat me, I will take it.' Let him first go and face the farmers, and then I will go and speak," Gowda said.

Speaking to reporters, he said, "The current CM Siddaramaiah is my old friend and former colleague. We worked together. But it deeply pains me that nobody seems to notice what is happening here." He further said that his son and former CM HD Kumaraswamy had earlier abandoned five township projects around the city due

to public opposition.

"Even now, people are angry and opposed to the Bidadi Township project. Therefore, the project must be withdrawn immediately," he demanded.

Criticising the current administration, Gowda, again referring to Shivakumar without naming him, said, "One individual has taken responsibility for Bengaluru, irrigation, and even the affairs of a national party.

Apparently, there's an agreement for someone to become CM. He entertains you people in the media with CM power struggles, while the farmers of Bidadi wipe tears from their eyes."

Addressing Siddaramaiah directly, the former PM said, "Siddaramaiah, you have worked with me. I know your commitment to social justice."

He added, "I have already written a letter asking for an investigation into whose names around 20,000 acres of land around Bengaluru are registered under. But you are yielding to pressure from those in charge of Bengaluru and are not listening to the people's problems."

He questioned, "Has anyone gone and listened to the problems of Bidadi farmers?" He alleged that fertile land was being targeted in the name of the town-

ship project and demanded that the Government clarify to whom the land would ultimately be handed over. "In this region, farmers are engaged in large-scale dairy farming and horticulture. Every day, huge quantities of milk are supplied to dairies. Earlier, Kumaraswamy implemented irrigation projects worth ₹250 crore for the benefit of this area. Now your party's state president is trying to take away these irrigated lands," Gowda said, addressing Siddaramaiah.

"You have spoken about social justice for the poor and backward classes. This is the time to take a stand. Don't bow to pressure from

those handling Bengaluru affairs and commit injustice against ordinary people. The farmers of Bidadi are in tears," he added.

Deve Gowda also criticised those saying they would continue what Kumaraswamy had started. "Kumaraswamy stopped the project because people opposed it," he said, asking, "Shouldn't this person also stop it?"

"Despite severe public opposition, they insist they will complete the township project. I have written a letter to CM Siddaramaiah regarding this. My struggle begins. We must curb the forces trying to grab poor people's lands around here.

FROM PAGE - 1

India no longer bound by borders: PM

"We are continuously reducing compliance and increasing the ease of doing business. We have recently carried out next-generation reforms in taxation, labour code, and governance," he told the business leaders.

"Today, our India too is dreaming on a very grand scale. Today, the nation is saying – we do not seek merely transformation; we seek the best. And not only the best, but we want the fastest. That is why, when aspirations in India are unlimited, our efforts too are becoming limitless," Prime Minister said.

Modi said the youth of India aspire to touch the skies now, and cited that as a reason behind India's startup ecosystem getting stronger. "Now we are the third-largest startup ecosystem in the world," he added. "Today, India's aspirations are not limited merely to its own borders. India wishes to host the Olympics, become a global manufacturing hub, emerge as a leader in green energy, and serve as an engine of growth for the world," he said. Modi said that India is passing through a phase of "unprecedented transformation".

He further said, "You may have seen recently that India hosted the world's largest and most success-

ful AI Summit. Before that, India had also successfully hosted the G20 New Delhi Summit. These were not merely one-time events; this has now become the character and confidence of today's India."

"India reached a part of the Moon where no one had reached before. India is also successfully working on one of the world's most advanced fast breeder reactors in the field of nuclear energy," said Modi, referring to India's space mission and energy sector. "Today, our startups are doing remarkable work in sectors such as AI, defence, and space. With time, this culture of research and innovation is becoming even more expansive," he said.

Andhra's Hum Do to be incentivised for...

As a result, he warned that the state's population growth rate is declining and stressed the importance of maintaining the replacement-level Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of 2.1.

He noted that a population remains stable only when the fertility rate is 2.1 children per woman. He emphasised that declining populations and ageing societies in several countries have adversely affected their economies. Referring to the

Talliki Vandanam welfare scheme, which provides Rs 15,000 per school-going child per annum, Naidu said he would increase the amount "if God shows mercy". On this AP Health Minister Satya Kumar Yadav said that this is nothing new since the government had decided to extend the incentives to families having a third child and beyond.

NEET-UG leak probe deepens; main accused...

During these sessions, Mandhare reviewed and explained Botany and Zoology questions, instructing students to record them in their notebooks and textbooks. Most of these questions later appeared on the NEET UG 2026 Examination held on May 3, 2026. Reports indicate that these sessions took place at a private residence in Pune in late April 2026. Students received exam questions and answers, and forensic analysis later verified that their notes matched the actual NEET-UG 2026 exam given on May 3.

The breach was uncovered after a whistle-blower reported finding a WhatsApp 'guess paper' identical to the real exam. This prompted the National Testing Agency (NTA) to cancel the test on May 12.

The NTA has set a re-test for June 21 at no extra cost for candidates and announced that NEET will move fully to a computer-based format in 2027. Investigators traced approximately 710 lakh to accounts linked to Mandhare, who was arrested alongside another suspect from Ahilyanagar.

CBI teams have searched 14 locations in Maharashtra and Rajasthan, detaining seven more suspects. They seized Mandhare's electronic devices and documents for forensic analysis. Authorities are investigating possible wider involvement in the exam system. All accused remain in police custody for seven days.

The incident affected over 2.2 million candidates and triggered nationwide protests. It has also been linked to the reported suicides of at least two students. The CBI has pledged a thorough, prompt investigation to restore public trust as thousands of NEET candidates await a fair resolution.

Curriculum shift: CBSE mandates 3 languages...

Overseas CBSE schools and returning students from abroad may also be granted flexibility in language selection. Education experts view the policy as an important step toward the NEP's goal of multilin-

gual proficiency. Research shows that learning multiple languages enhances cognitive skills, problem-solving, and cultural empathy.

By requiring at least two Indian languages, CBSE seeks to promote national integration and preserve linguistic heritage. A senior CBSE official stated that this initiative will prepare students for a global future while maintaining cultural roots. However, challenges remain. Many schools, especially in urban areas, may face shortages of qualified regional language teachers. Parents are concerned about the increased academic workload for Class 9 students, who already manage dual-level Mathematics and Science. Some also worry about reduced access to foreign-language electives, which are important for studying abroad. Schools have been directed to hold parent-teacher meetings and provide support for students moving from two-language streams.

The policy highlights CBSE's commitment to competency-based, experiential learning over rote examination. The success of the 2026-27 session will depend on effective teacher training and sufficient resources. For many students, this reform marks a shift from exam-focused education to a balanced, multilingual approach that values both academic achievement and cultural identity. The coming months will determine the policy's effectiveness.

CJI clarifies parasites remarks, says pained over media reports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Saturday issued a strongly worded clarification on his 'parasites' remarks, saying he was "pained" by media reports that suggested he criticised youth.

"I am pained to read how a section of the media has misquoted my oral observations made during the hearing of a frivolous case yesterday," the CJI said in a statement.

Kant emphasised that his remarks were specifically directed at individuals entering the legal profession through "fake and bogus degrees" and were "misquoted by a section of the media."

The clarification follows a controversy during a hearing on Friday, when the CJI used words like "parasites" and "cockroaches" while pulling up a lawyer for his



CJI Kant speaking during the launch of the 'Fragmentation to Fusion: Empowering Justice via United Digital Platform Integration' at Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Cultural & Information Centre in Jabalpur, Madhya Pradesh on Saturday

plea seeking senior designation.

"What I had specifically criticised were those who have entered professions like the Bar (legal profession) with the aid of fake and bogus degrees. Similar persons have sneaked into the media, social media, and other noble professions as well, and hence, they are like parasites. "It is totally baseless to suggest

that I criticised the youth of our nation. Not only am I proud of our present and future human resource, but every youth of India inspires me. It is not an exaggeration to say that Indian youth have great regard and respect for me, and I too see them as the pillars of a developed India," the chief justice said about his remarks.

Delhi Court grants bail to Vadra in ED case over Shikohpur land deal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's Rouse Avenue district court on Saturday granted bail to Robert Vadra in Enforcement Directorate's (ED) money laundering case over Shikohpur land deal. Special Judge (PC Act) Sushant Changotra granted bail upon payment of ₹50,000 thousand as surety.

ED had filed charge sheet in

the case without arresting Vadra. ED's counsel Zoheb Hossain appeared online and informed the court that ED is filing a status report and also sought two weeks' time to file another status report after conducting further investigation.

He told the court that the order of cognisance has also been challenged by Vadra and other accused persons, before High Court.

CPI(M) terms Bhojshala verdict unfortunate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) has expressed grave concern over the Madhya Pradesh High Court judgment regarding the Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque dispute, terming the verdict "unfortunate" with dangerous implications for the secular and democratic foundations of the Indian republic.

In a press statement issued from the CPI(M) Central Committee Office, the party highlighted that by setting aside the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) order that granted Muslims the right to pray at the complex, the High Court has echoed the same legal reasoning used by the Supreme Court in the Babri Masjid-Ramjanmabhoomi title suit. The party warned that this ruling is bound to



People offer prayers after the MP High Court verdict declare the Bhojshala complex a Hindu temple dedicated to Goddess Vagdevi (Saraswati) in Dhar MP

have a significant, cascading bearing on similar historical disputes across the country.

The Polit Bureau noted that the judgment cannot be viewed in isolation from a growing, troubling trend

where historical and religious disputes are increasingly being reopened and adjudicated in manners that risk deepening communal fractures. Critically, the CPI(M) argued that the High Court appeared unwilling to consider the Places of Worship Act, 1991 — a piece of legislation enacted by Parliament specifically to prevent endless communal contestations over religious sites. The party stated that the MP High Court judgment stands in complete contravention of the provisions of this Act.

The CPI(M) asserted that the ruling would only serve to aid communal forces, specifically pointing towards the BJP-RSS combine. The party accused these groups of consistently foregrounding divisive religious issues to divert public attention from the pressing livelihood concerns facing ordinary citizens.

India seizes 1st Captagon haul worth ₹182 crore in Operation RAGEPILL

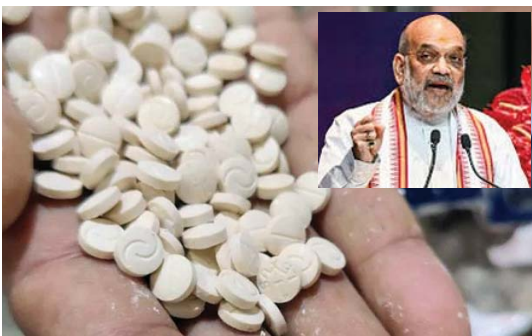
PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

India has reached a major milestone in its efforts against narcotics with the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) achieving the country's first-ever seizure of Captagon, also known as the 'Jihadi Drug', during a targeted operation codenamed 'Operation RAGEPILL'. This seizure is valued at approximately ₹182 crore in the international market.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah stated on X that the Government remains committed to a 'Drug-Free India', noting that 'Operation RAGEPILL' resulted in the first-ever seizure of Captagon, valued at ₹182 crore. He emphasised that intercepting the consignment destined for the Middle East and arresting a foreign national exemplifies the Government's zero-tolerance approach to drug trafficking. Shah reiterated the intention to prevent any drugs from entering or leaving India via its territory and commended the efforts of the NCB personnel.

Captagon is the brand name for 'Fenethylamine', a synthetic amphetamine-type stimulant developed in the 1960s as a pharmaceutical treatment for conditions such as ADHD and narcolepsy. It combines amphetamine with theophylline, a compound found in tea and chocolate, to induce prolonged alertness, euphoria, and reduced fatigue.

Due to its high potential for abuse, Captagon is banned in most countries and has become a major illicit drug, predominantly manufactured in conflict zones such as Syria and Lebanon. It is often referred



to as the "Jihadi Drug" or "chemical courage".

Reports suggest that terrorist groups, including ISIS fighters in Syria and Iraq, have used Captagon to suppress fear, hunger, and pain while enhancing stamina during combat. Its addictive properties facilitate both recreational misuse in Gulf countries and the financing of illicit networks. The global trade in Captagon is substantial and frequently linked to production in the Middle East.

India's seizure marks the first confirmed interception of Captagon on Indian soil, indicating emerging attempts by Middle Eastern syndicates to exploit Indian ports and logistics for export routes. During Operation RAGEPILL, NCB officers reportedly intercepted approximately 200 kg of Captagon tablets concealed within consignments disguised as legitimate cargo. The drugs were hidden in boxes declared as containing tea leaves or wool and arrived via container at Mundra Port in Gujarat, one of India's busiest commercial gateways. Further recoveries and leads indicated connections to operations in Delhi's Neb Sarai area.

Saudi Arabia (West Asia/Middle East), indicating a typical transit pattern

via India. A Syrian national operating from Delhi was arrested. Agencies are actively probing potential terror links. This step comes given the drug's known associations with terror financing.

The operation demonstrates intelligence-driven and multi-agency coordination, consistent with the NCB's recent high-profile actions. This strategy aligns with India's broader anti-narcotics framework. Between 2020 and 2024, drugs valued at over ₹11,311 crore were seized in 19 major port operations.

This bust does not occur in isolation. Under the Modi Government's directives, the NCB and allied agencies have intensified operations against both traditional drugs (heroin, hashish) and emerging synthetics. Key initiatives include: Operation Samudragupt and similar maritime interdictions targeting "motherships" smuggling drugs from Afghanistan/Pakistan routes.

The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), a specialised security force for key infrastructure, currently secures 13 major ports and plans to expand further. Additionally, the newly established Bureau of Port Security (BoPS) is responsible for advanced cargo screening at these facilities.

States Focus



Shivakumar: One Nation One Election unworkable

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Saturday strongly opposed the central Government's proposed 'One Nation One Election' initiative.

Shivakumar expressed his views at a dialogue on 'One Nation One Election' organised by the Joint Parliamentary Study Committee. He said the plan is a politically motivated, power-centralising scheme that would seriously damage India's federal structure by weakening states and poses a threat to the democratic system, according to a statement from his office. As KPCC president and deputy CM of Karnataka, he categorically rejected the proposal, stating that it is being crafted to suit the convenience of those in power at the Centre.



Cancellation and regulation of trains: Northern Railway

The Northern Railway has issued that due to a 5.30 hours power and traffic block on the Delhi Jn – Shamli – Saharanpur Jn single line section, the following trains shall remain temporarily cancelled/regulated.

The following are the trains which will remain cancelled. Train no 64021 Delhi Jn – Shamli JCO 24.06.2026 will be cancelled, and train no 64020 Shamli – Delhi Jn JCO 25.06.2026 will also be cancelled.

On the other hand, the regulation of train are train no 54058 Shamli – Delhi Jn JCO 25.06.2026 will be regulated for 30 minutes at Kandhla. For further updates, kindly visit NTES or dial 139.

CITU condemns use of NSA against Noida activists

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) Delhi State Committee has strongly condemned the Uttar Pradesh Government's decision to invoke the National Security Act (NSA) against two activists involved in the ongoing workers' struggle in Noida.

In a statement issued by CITU President Virender Gaur and General Secretary Aniyvan PV, the trade union alleged that the UP Government has been attempting to give a "law and order twist" to the agitation from day one to crack down on the workers.

Terming the issue a pure labour dispute, CITU maintained that it is the statutory duty of the state labour department to resolve the matter through tripartite



conciliation mechanisms rather than deploying police force.

CITU highlighted the severe economic distress faced by industrial workers across the Delhi National Capital Region (NCR).

At the start of the strike, the minimum monthly wages for unskilled workers

stood at a below-par ₹11,314 in Uttar Pradesh and ₹11,257 in Haryana. Despite the revised minimum wages being set at ₹13,690 in UP and ₹15,221 in Haryana, several firms have refused to implement the hiked rates.

The union criticised the UP labour department for failing to take action against these

non-compliant companies.

The statement further accused the Noida Police of attempting an illegal clampdown on trade union activities, including a failed bid to stop the workers from celebrating May Day.

CITU also criticised the UP Police's move to create a DCP (Industry) post, calling it an illegal mechanism to meddle in industrial disputes. Extending its criticism to the Centre, CITU noted that the first year of the BJP Government in Delhi has compounded workers' miseries by refusing to hike the variable dearness allowance (DA) since October 2025.

CITU has demanded the immediate release of all workers detained under unproven allegations and called for the immediate fixation of a uniform minimum wage of ₹26,000 per month across the entire Delhi NCR.

IIT Jammu to set up satellite campus in Leh, Ladakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

In a landmark step towards strengthening higher and technical education in Ladakh, IIT Jammu will set up its Satellite Campus in Leh.

A Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to this effect was signed between the UT Administration of Ladakh and IIT Jammu on Saturday in the presence of Lieutenant Governor, Vinai Kumar Saxena, who described the initiative as a "historic and transformational moment" for the youth of Ladakh and said this would create pathways for aspiration, excellence and achievement.

The MoU was signed by Director, IIT Jammu, Prof Manoj Singh Gaur and Secretary, Higher Education Department, UT Ladakh, Bhanu Prabha.

The development assumes great significance, as for decades, students from Ladakh faced grave challenges in pursuing higher and technical education.

For want of a quality technical institution in Ladakh, Ladakhi youths were forced to travel thousands of kilometres, away from home, to study in prestigious institutions. For families living in difficult



and remote regions, this often meant emotional hardship, financial burden, and social challenges. However, this collaboration with IIT Jammu would now provide talented students from Ladakh with access to high-quality education closer to their home and open a world of opportunities in research, innovation, entrepreneurship and employment.

As per the MoU, in the initial phase, around 40 students from Ladakh will begin pursuing courses at the IIT campus in Jammu from the July – August 2026 academic session onwards.

Subsequently, a temporary Satellite Campus of IIT Jammu will be established at the Government Polytechnic College in Leh to facilitate academic

activities within Ladakh. In the long term, a full-fledged residential engineering campus is proposed to be developed in Kargil.

To begin with, the campus will offer two future-oriented disciplines — Civil Engineering and Artificial Intelligence & Data Science.

LG Saxena stated that the collaboration would open the doors of world-class technical education for students from the remote and high-altitude regions of Ladakh and reduce the long-standing educational challenges faced by local families. He noted that the collaboration would create opportunities for faculty exchange, research partnerships, startup incubation, innovation centres and skill development.

NIA chargesheets five including kingpin in Cambodia trafficking case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has chargesheeted five persons, including the alleged mastermind, in a case related to trafficking and cyber slavery of Indian youths in Cambodia, officials said on Saturday.

The alleged kingpin of the human trafficking syndicate — Anand Kumar Singh alias Munna Singh, who is absconding — along with four co-accused, have been named in the chargesheet filed before the NIA special court in Bihar's Patna on Friday, they said.

The NIA investigation has found Anand to be the kingpin, involved in recruitment of youth through various sub-agents/travel agents in India.

He was working with associates in Cambodia to illegally traffic the victims to that country, an NIA statement issued



here on Saturday said.

Anand was charging \$2,000-3,000 for each youth 'sold' to a fake company, it said.

The accused were involved in luring Indian youths to Cambodia on the pretext of legitimate jobs and handsome salaries, as part of an organised human trafficking syndicate.

Upon their arrival in Cambodia, the victims' passports were seized and they were forced to work for "scam companies", and any resistance on their part was met with mental and physical torture, including electric shocks, forceful confinement, denial of food and water etc, the NIA said.

CBSE defends new OSM marking amid class 12 result complaints

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With alleged reports of major goof ups in the new marking system of the recently released class 12th CBSE results, the board on Saturday clarified the Board is extremely sensitive to their concerns and is alive to addressing it accordingly.

In a statement it said that many students of class XII Board are anxious about their results/marks and are attributing it to change of assessment scheme ie On-Screen Marking (OSM) mechanism re-introduced this year. The CBSE reiterates that student well-being is of paramount importance and, therefore, has attempted to address all possible issues which could arise.

The key benefits of OSM are uniformity in evaluation with adherence to the marking scheme prepared by experienced CBSE teachers. The marking scheme also contains alternative methods of answering so that children who answer



deploying alternative methods are also graded.

If any student feels dissatisfied with the result, there are clear and transparent avenues available, including verification of marks, access to evaluated answer books, and re-evaluation. For those feeling anxious or uncertain, tele-counselling support (1800-11-8004) is also available.

They may also reach out through the email resultcbse2026@gmail.com. We would encourage students and parents to directly use these official channels to seek clarity and support, for any unanswered doubts. Every concern deserves attention, and no student is alone

in this process, added CBSE. "The CBSE is an institution that works in the best interest of the students, and we operate with complete transparency. We evaluate approximately 1.25 crore answer scripts; there is a possibility that an error may occur somewhere.

To rectify such errors, we offer certain facilities to our students. The first facility allows our students to request a copy of their evaluated answer scripts.

The window to request these answer scripts will open on the 19th, and students may apply for them until the 22nd. Once they receive their answer scripts, they can review them to check if there are any errors within them.

If they identify any errors, they should make a note of them; subsequently, a second window will open from the 26th to the 29th, during which they can apply to report that there are issues or discrepancies in their answer scripts that need to be addressed.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

At an interactive session hosted by 'Uniform Unveiled' at the Manekshaw Centre in the national Capital, he was asked about how the Indian Army will respond if the circumstances that led to Operation Sindoor last year come up again.

General Dwivedi's remarks, though brief carried a blunt message to Pakistan, and reiterated India's stand against terrorism. Operation Sindoor was launched early on May 7 last year in retaliation to the deadly



At the interactive session, Dwivedi not only offered leadership lessons to them, but also

The Army chief urged the youths to stay fit, work hard, develop leadership qualities, and choose physical activities over

During the fireside chat, he was asked about his future plans beyond his role in the military uniform. "I think maybe at the level of colonel only, I realised that it is time to pay back to society, which has catapulted you to such a height. Because it is time for you to say thanks, appreciate, for whatever you have been able to gain during these times," the Army Chief said.

DMK President MK Stalin, who has constituted a 36-member committee to probe the reasons behind the party's shock defeat in the April 23 Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, has asked it to submit the report by early July.

The DMK, which contested in 169 constituencies, could secure a win in only 59 assembly seats to become main opposition party after TVK won the polls.

The DMK chief has asked the team to submit a detailed report by July 5. "Your sole duty is to convey to me, exactly as they are, the facts provided by party members without any personal bias or prejudice", he said in a statement. The "fact-finding" team should not attempt to shield anyone and "party members should be allowed to speak their mind freely," he added. (PTI)

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 Hyderabad/New Delhi

In a statement he said the Central leadership was fully aware of the proposed hikes much before the completion of elections in five States. To avoid political damage during elections, the BJP Government deliberately held back the price revision and cheated the people of India.

paper leak case is extremely unfortunate, insensitive and politically motivated. He should abandon the politics of confusion and first Introspect, the BJP leader said in a statement.

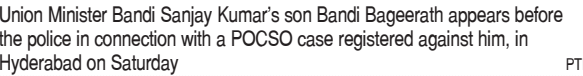
However, a string of subjects/portfolios such as Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments, Excise and Prohibition, Transport, Revenue, Social Welfare, Labour welfare, Housing, Tourism, Information Technology, Handlooms and Textiles, Commercial Taxes, Backward Classes Welfare, Environment, Minorities



P Venkataramanan has been allocated Food and Civil Supplies, while R Nirmalkumar will handle Energy Resources and Law. Rajmohan shall be the Minister for School Education, Tamil Development, Information and Publicity.

"A paper of NEET exam may get leaked, but in Army (an exam) paper leak doesn't happen, and (an exam) paper leak doesn't happen in the Air Force. And, we we have devised systems which are absolutely fair, you can't

However, Bandi Sanjay said he had asked his son to appear before the police and join the probe. "Satya Meva Jayate. With utmost respect for the law and judiciary, today my son Bandi



The development came a day after the Telangana High Court refused to grant interim protection from arrest to Bageerath.



PROSPECT

NHPC Q4 PROFIT GROWS 68 PER CENT TO ₹1,549 CRORE



State-owned NHPC has posted over 68 per cent jump in consolidated net profit at ₹1,549.42 crore for the March quarter 2025-26, supported by higher revenues. It had logged a profit of ₹919.63 crore in the year-ago period, the company said in an exchange filing on Friday. Total income during the period increased to ₹3,120.52 crore from ₹2,557.71 crore in the fourth quarter of 2024-25. Annual net profit was at ₹4,220.46 crore as against ₹3,411.73 crore. Total income was at ₹12,686.09 crore as compared to ₹11,614.61 crore earlier. The company's board also approved a final dividend of 21 paise per equity share for FY26. In a separate statement, NHPC said during FY 2025-26, it added capacity of 1850 MW by commissioning 3 projects, namely Subansiri Lower Project (750 MW out of 2000), Parbati-II Project (800 MW) and Karnisar Solar Project (300 MW). This is the highest capacity addition during any fiscal year in its history. Further, power stations of the company achieved generation of 23307 Million Units (MUs) in FY 2025-26 with installed capacity of 7401 MW from 25 power stations on a standalone basis. NHPC, along with its subsidiaries and joint ventures, presently has an installed capacity of 9333 MW from 31 power stations and is engaged in the construction of 17 projects aggregating to a total installed capacity of 9204 MW.

CCPA orders probe into herbicide sale on key e-commerce sites

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE New Delhi

Four major e-commerce platforms, Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho and JioMart, have delisted an allegedly unregistered agro-chemical product following notices issued by the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA), which has since ordered a detailed investigation into the matter. The platforms informed the regulator that listings of "Cyclosinone Herbicide" had been removed with immediate effect and that seller accounts associated with such listings had been placed under scrutiny, the regulator said in a statement on Saturday. The CCPA, however, said the responses were only a first step and directed that the matter be taken up for comprehensive investigation. "The CCPA has placed the matter for detailed investigation," the regulator said. The notices were originally issued following a complaint by the Crop Care Federation of India (CCFI), forwarded by the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, alleging that the her-



bicide was being actively sold and promoted online despite not featuring in the Schedule to the Insecticides Act, 1968. The complaint further flagged that product listings failed to disclose the active ingredient and its precise chemical identity," information considered essential for informed purchasing, particularly by farmers. On examining the matter, the CCPA found that the listings lacked disclosure of the product's chemical composition, valid licence numbers and their period of validity, mandatory statutory warn-

platforms to verify seller licences before permitting such listings. Failure to do so, the authority said, amounted to violations of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019 and the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020. As part of its notices, the platforms were directed to furnish details, including the date of initial listing, total number of listings since January 2024, complete particulars of associated sellers, and the due diligence mechanisms in place to ensure regulatory compliance. "Digital convenience cannot come at the cost of consumer protection, statutory non-compliance, or public safety," the CCPA said, adding that e-commerce platforms bear significant responsibility for ensuring products sold through their marketplaces comply with applicable law. The authority said it would continue to take stringent measures against misleading advertisements, unfair trade practices, and the online sale of products that may pose risks to consumers," particularly in sectors touching public health, agriculture, and safety.

Rekha Gupta distributes bicycles to girl students



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, on Saturday, attended an event in the RK Puram Assembly constituency, where she distributed bicycles to girls who excelled in Classes 10 and 12. This initiative supports students' continued education by improving access, safety, and independence. The Chief Minister highlighted the significance of girls' education and thanked the organisers for their efforts. Organised by the Rotary Club of Delhi Imperial (District 3012) under the leadership of President Rtn. Rajesh Modi and Hon. Secretary Rtn. Pankaj Agarwal, the grand Cycle Donation Drive was held at the Kerala School in RK Puram. The initiative specifically recognised high-achieving Class 12 students who secured 80 per cent and above in their board examinations. Event Convenor Dinesh Gupta emphasised that the choice of bicycles was intentional, aiming to promote both health and environmental consciousness. The high-profile ceremony was also attended by several notable dignitaries as Guests of Honour, including New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj and District Governor

Rtn Dr Amita Mohindru. The chief minister stated that girls' education is essential for the progress of families, society, and the nation. She described the bicycle as a tool that builds students' confidence, independence, and hope. The Chief Minister announced that the Delhi Government has decided to provide bicycles to all girls taking admission in Class 9 in Government schools. Around 1.30 lakh girls enrol in Class 9 every year, and these bicycles will help them commute to school, college, and coaching centres. She said the process of bicycle distribution will begin after the summer vacation. The Chief Minister praised RK Puram MLA Anil Sharma and the Rotary Club Delhi Imperial for distributing bicycles to over 500 students before the Government program began. She thanked the Rotary Club and all project participants. She also reaffirmed the Delhi Government's commitment to expanding opportunities, safety, and support for girls' education. The goal is to ensure that no girl abandons her studies or aspirations due to a lack of resources. Several dignitaries, including BJP District President Ravindra Chaudhary, attended the event.

Himanta inaugurates India's first AI-powered bank branch in Guwahati

TONY DAS Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday inaugurated "India's first AI and digital-powered" bank branch in Guwahati, aimed at boosting financial inclusion and opening new opportunities for the youth. The AI-powered 'phygital' branch of Slice Small Finance Bank was unveiled at GS Road. Speaking on the occasion, Sarma said this branch rep-

resents another step toward building a more inclusive financial ecosystem across both urban and underserved communities. He said the bank's opening, with its "unique services", represents the right kind of investment the state government has been working on for some time. The inauguration of this branch also speaks about Assam's readiness in supporting and encouraging future of Indian banking, the CM said.



Sarma said customers in the bank would be able to access credit directly through the UPI interface without a separate application for the same. "This would help small store owners and women entrepreneurs get access to working capital for their business ventures on their phones in minutes," he said. Sarma asserted that the Assam government is committed to making the state a destination for responsible and technology-driven investment.

He also said that the government is "relentless in creating conditions where businesses can thrive, where young people can find opportunity, and where every resident has access to the financial tools they need to build a better life". The bank "seamlessly blends physical and digital services through AI-enabled self-service kiosks, paperless cash deposits and withdrawals, and streamlined digital onboarding", CM said.

TCS CEO Krithivasan takes home ₹28 crore as remuneration in FY26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE Mumbai

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director K Krithivasan took home a total remuneration of ₹28 crore in 2025-26, marking an increase of 6.3 per cent over the previous year, according to the company's latest annual report. Meanwhile, Tata Group and TCS Chairman N Chandrasekaran abstained from receiving any commission from the IT major, drawing only ₹4.2 lakh in sitting fees for the entire fiscal year. "As a policy, N Chandrasekaran, Chairman, has abstained from receiving commission from the company and hence not stated," the annual report said. Krithivasan's compensation package for the fiscal year included a basic salary of ₹1.67 crore, benefits, perquisites, and allowances of ₹1.43 crore, and a performance-linked commission of ₹25 crore.



According to the IT major's annual report for FY 2025-26, the CEO's remuneration was 332.8 times the median remuneration of TCS employees. The report noted that the median remuneration of employees increased by 5.1 per cent during the fiscal year. The average annual salary increase for junior and mid-level employees in India was in the range of 4.5 per cent to 7 per cent, with top performers receiving double-

digit increments. TCS reported a 12.22 per cent jump in its March quarter net profit at ₹13,718 crore. For fiscal year 2025-26, its profit after tax inched up 1.35 per cent to ₹49,210 crore, as against ₹48,553 crore in FY25. Revenue from operations jumped 9.64 per cent to Rs 70,698 crore in Q4 FY26, while the same for the full fiscal was higher by 4.58 per cent to ₹2.67 lakh crore.

POWERGRID profit hits ₹15,928 crore for FY26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE New Delhi

Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), a 'Maharatna' enterprise under the Ministry of Power, has announced its financial results for the fourth quarter and the full financial year ending March 31, 2026. On a consolidated basis, the state-run transmission major posted a Profit After Tax (PAT) of ₹15,928 crore and a Total Income of ₹47,684 crore for FY26. On a standalone basis, the company's PAT and Total Income stood at ₹15,921 crore and ₹46,996 crore, respectively. For the final quarter of the fiscal (Q4FY26), POWERGRID reported a consolidated PAT of ₹4,546 crore and a Total Income of ₹11,971 crore. Meanwhile, its standalone PAT for the same three-month period was recorded at ₹4,553 crore against a Total Income of ₹11,955 crore. The company's Board has proposed a final dividend of ₹1.25 per equity share on a



face value of ₹10 each, which equals 12.50 per cent of the paid-up share capital. This comes in addition to the interim dividend of ₹7.75 per share already paid out during the fiscal year, bringing the total dividend for the year to ₹9 per share. By the close of FY26, the total transmission assets held by POWERGRID and its subsidiaries expanded to 1,84,960 circuit kilometres (ckm) of transmission lines, 291 substations, and a massive 6,24,016 MVA of transformation capacity. The energy major successfully maintained an impressive average transmission system availability of 99.84 per cent throughout the financial year.

NCC Aqua Adventure Regatta culminates in Meghalaya

TONY DAS Shillong

The Aqua Adventure Regatta 2026, organised by the 12 Assam NCC Battalion, culminated successfully at the picturesque Umiam Lake in Meghalaya on Saturday. Run under the aegis of the NCC Group Jorhat and the NCC North Eastern Region Directorate Shillong, the event marked the end of an enriching and adventurous eight-day training camp conducted from May 9 to 16. The camp witnessed the enthusiastic participation of 100 NCC cadets, including Senior Division (boys) and Senior Wing (girls) cadres drawn from various institutions across the region. Throughout the intensive eight-day capsule, the cadets underwent rigorous training and gained hands-on exposure to a diverse array of aqua adventure activities. These included professional training in sailing, boat pulling, watermanship, team-building exercises, and specialised adventure-based leadership drills.



According to a defence release, the primary objective of the regatta was to foster discipline, courage, camaraderie, leadership qualities, and self-confidence among the young cadres, while simultaneously promoting a robust spirit of adventure and national integration. The participating cadets displayed exceptional enthusiasm, determination, and exemplary teamwork throughout the duration of the camp. The grand closing ceremony was marked by vibrant cultural performances, a prize distribution ceremony, and the felicitation of cadets who excelled in various adventure activities and competitions. Camp Commandant Lt Col Atong

Konyak K presented certificates and awards to the deserving cadets in recognition of their outstanding performance, dedication, and sportsmanship. As part of the culmination activities, the cadets were also taken for sightseeing visits to prominent tourist landmarks around Shillong, including the iconic Shillong Peak, allowing them to experience the natural beauty and rich cultural heritage of Meghalaya. Organisers stated that the successful conduct of the regatta reflects the steadfast commitment of the NCC towards holistic youth development through adventure, strict discipline, and character-building initiatives.

Central Bank sanctions ₹127 cr via MSME outreach

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE New Delhi

The Central Bank of India (CBI) successfully organised a "Nation Wide Mega MSME Credit Outreach Program" at Narela in North Delhi, sanctioning loans worth ₹127 crore to boost small and medium enterprises. The mega credit camp, held at Shiv Mandir Agarwal Dharamshala in Purani Anaj Mandi, Narela, was conducted under the guidance of CBI Delhi South Regional Head Munish Kumar, Zonal Office Deputy General Manager Anil Kumar, and Deputy Regional Head Mandeep Kumar. The programme witnessed enthusiastic participation from a large number of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) customers, local entrepreneurs,



and various industrial business units from the region. During the main event, MSME loan sanction letters were distributed directly to the beneficiaries by the Regional Head, marking a significant step towards strengthening

institutional credit support for the local manufacturing and trading sector. Simultaneously, special credit camps were held at different strategic locations by various bank branches falling under the Delhi South

region, culminating in the aggregate sanction of loans amounting to ₹127 crore. To ensure seamless banking support and provide prompt assistance to the visiting entrepreneurs, the bank established dedicated customer service stalls and facilitation desks at the venue. The participants actively shared their feedback and suggestions during the interactive sessions of the programme. Senior bank officials stated that the high-volume credit outreach event reflects the continued commitment of the Central Bank of India towards empowering MSMEs, fostering entrepreneurship, and promoting inclusive economic growth through proactive, customer-centric banking initiatives in the national Capital.

Chouhan calls for science-led farming roadmaps amid climate change threats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE New Delhi

Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Saturday underscored the urgency of adopting science-based agricultural practices, citing the increasingly visible impact of climate change on farming across India and globally. At a meeting convened to review the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) proposals of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), Chouhan directed officials to fast-track the preparation of state-specific agricultural roadmaps aligned with the agro-climatic conditions of each State, in consultation with respective State Governments. Officials informed the



Minister that the exercise is already underway, with Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Assam and Rajasthan among the states that have formally requested such roadmaps, which are expected to be finalised shortly, an official statement said.

Chouhan, expressing satisfaction with ICAR's action plan, urged officials to accelerate implementation with the aim of meeting targets ahead of schedule. ICAR Director General and Secretary of the Department of Agricultural Research and Education (DARE), Dr ML Jat,

briefed the Minister on the council's programmes and activities, as well as its future strategy to maximise benefits for farmers and Indian agriculture broadly. The Minister reiterated that agriculture remains the primary livelihood for a large share of the population and a bedrock of the Indian economy. He called for all efforts to be directed at making farming more productive, cost-efficient and financially rewarding for cultivators. Chouhan also stressed the need for wide-scale promotion of integrated farming, urging that farmers be encouraged to adopt the model practically, saying it would boost incomes while advancing sustainable agricultural practices.

FROM THE

WORLD

IRAN

Pak minister visits Tehran

Pakistan's Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi on Saturday held talks with his Iranian counterpart in Tehran on bilateral ties to end the US-Iran conflict, according to a media report. Pakistan hosted the talks between the US and Iran last month but they failed to bridge the differences and a second round is still pending even as the two sides have been exchanging peace proposals through Islamabad. Naqvi, who reached Tehran earlier in the day for a two-day official visit, was received at the airport by his Iranian counterpart Eskandar Mo'meni, Iran's semi-official news agency Tasnim said. The two interior ministers held a bilateral meeting during which they engaged in detailed discussions on Iran-Pakistan relations and the prospects for the resumption of peace negotiations, the news agency said.

USA

USS Ford returns home

The USS Gerald R Ford, the world largest aircraft carrier, returned home to Virginia on Saturday after an 11-month deployment, the longest since the Vietnam War, that saw it support the US war with Iran and the capture of Nicolas Maduro when he was Venezuela's president. The most advanced US warship and two accompanying destroyers docked at Naval Station Norfolk with about 5,000 sailors waiting to see their families for the first time since June. Besides combat operations and traversing continents, the sailors aboard the carrier faced a noncombat-related fire that left hundreds without places to sleep and forced lengthy repairs on the Greek island of Crete. Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth was on hand for the arrival of the warships, which included the destroyer USS Bainbridge. Hegseth commended the crew of the Bainbridge for a "job well done".

Israeli strike kills Hamas military wing leader in Gaza

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tel Aviv

An Israeli airstrike in Gaza killed the leader of Hamas' military wing, one of the last surviving architects of the October 7, 2023 attacks that triggered the war in Gaza, the Israeli military said on Saturday.

Izz al-Din al-Haddad was killed on Friday, Israel's army said, describing him as was one of the last senior commanders in Hamas' military who had directed the planning and execution of the October 7 Hamas-led attacks. The attacks killed some 1,200 people in Israel and saw more than 250 taken hostage into Gaza. Israel's retaliatory strikes have killed more than 72,700 people, according to the Gaza Health Ministry. The ministry is part of Gaza's Hamas-run Government, but staffed by



medical professionals who maintain and publish detailed records, viewed as generally reliable by the international community.

Al-Haddad's killing comes as the ceasefire between Israel and Hamas remains fragile as key issues like the disarmament of

Hamas stall the deal's progress. Despite the ceasefire, which went into effect in October, Gaza has seen near-daily Israeli fire with more than 850 people being killed since then, according to Gaza's Health Ministry.

Al-Haddad was the latest Hamas commander to be killed by Israel. Israel said he had assumed the role after his predecessor Mohammed Sinwar was killed. The army said al-Haddad had surrounded himself with Israeli hostages during the war as a shield against an attack.

Al-Haddad's family confirmed to The Associated Press his death in Friday's strike along with six other people.

His funeral was held Saturday in Gaza City. His body was wrapped in Hamas and Palestinians flags as it was carried by mourners. He joined Hamas

when it was established in the 1980s, and was a member of the Qassam Brigades' Majd section, which was tasked to go after co-laborators with Israel.

He was also a member of Hamas' Military Council, the highest group of commanders that played a key role in the attacks that sparked the war.

Israel's chief of staff for the army called his killing a significant operation, and said Israel would continue pursuing its enemies to hold them accountable.

Since the shaky ceasefire was reached, both Israel and Hamas have traded accusations of violations. Israel has targeted Hamas members inside the coastal enclave, the last of whom was the son of Hamas' lead negotiator, Khalil al-Hayya. Violence also flared Saturday in the occupied

West Bank, where Israeli troops shot and killed a 34-year-old Palestinian in the Jenin refugee camp, according to the Palestinian Health ministry.

Hassan Fayyad was fatally shot in his thigh, the Palestinian Red Crescent said. Israel's military said troops first fired warning shots at a person trying to infiltrate the Jenin camp and then shot him again when he didn't comply. They later provided him medical treatment as he was transferred to the hospital, it said.

Israeli troops on Thursday shot and killed a 15-year-old boy in Eastern Lubban town in Nablus, according to the Palestinian Health Ministry. Israel's military said it identified three people hurling rocks toward Israeli vehicles and "endangering lives," and troops fired at them, killing one of them.

Three gunmen detained following rare attack on two Nigerian primary schools

DYEPKAZAH SHIBAYAN
■ Abuja

Three gunmen who allegedly stormed into two primary schools in a rare attack in southwestern Nigeria were taken into custody, police said on Saturday.

Authorities were still assessing the number of school children that might have been abducted, police spokesperson Ayanlade Olayinka told *The Associated Press*. Gunmen attacked two primary schools in the Oriire area of Oyo state, about 220 kilometres from Lagos, in the early hours of Friday. The suspects, who were identified by the com-



munity, were arrested, Olayinka said.

Police didn't say if they were searching for more suspects. School attacks usually occur in the northern region where most armed groups operate. The attack happened hours apart from another assault, in which

suspected jihadi militants attacked a secondary school in Nigeria's northeastern Borno state on Friday.

Abduction of schoolchildren is common in Nigeria, where the Government is battling several armed groups across the country. Analysts say the armed groups, including Islamic militant group Boko Haram, often target schools for high ransoms, as they tend to gain the Government's attention. Last year, two mass abductions from schools rocked the West African nation, with more than 300 children taken in the conflict-battered northern region. (AP)

Bangladesh-India relations depend on Ganges Water Treaty renewal: BNP

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh's ruling BNP on Saturday said the country's relations with India "will depend on" a new Ganges Water Sharing Treaty as it sought immediate talks with New Delhi for an agreement in line with Dhaka's "expectations and needs".

The Indo-Bangladesh Ganges Water Sharing Treaty, signed in 1996, is due to expire in December.

"We want to send a clear message to the Indian government that a (new Ganges) treaty must be implemented immediately through discussions according to the expectations and needs of Bangladesh's people,"



Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) secretary general Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir said at an event here.

The opportunity to establish good relations with India "will depend on the signing of the Ganges Water Sharing

Treaty or the Farakka Agreement", said Alamgir, who is also the local government, rural development and cooperatives minister.

He alleged that the uncertainty over the renewal of the existing 30-year Ganges



People carrying a "mikoshi" portable shrine at Sensoji Buddhist temple as the nearby Asakusa Shrine holds the Sanja Matsuri, a Shinto festival in Tokyo

AP

Indian mango varieties now available at retail chains in Greater Seattle

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The sweet aroma of the 'Kesar' variety of Indian mangoes is wafting through select stores in Seattle, tickling the taste buds of food connoisseurs.

A year-long initiative by the Indian Consulate General in Seattle paved the way for several varieties of Indian mangoes to be available at retail chains such as 'Costco'.

The story of Indian mangoes in the US dates back to 2006, when then US President George W Bush cleared the way for shipping the fruit to American shores - news welcomed as enthusiastically as the marquee announcement of working toward the India-US civil nuclear deal.

India's Consul General in Seattle, Prakash Gupta, spoke about Indian mangoes on a special segment of 'Good Day Seattle' on Fox 13 News and brought a wide variety of the fruit for tasting in the TV studio. "We believe these are already in some of the local Indian grocery stores. (PTI)



Cargo train hits public bus in Bangkok, eight people killed

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangkok

A train crashed into a public bus on Saturday in Thailand's capital, Bangkok, killing at least eight people.

Thai news reported the crash happened in the late afternoon near an airport railway station in the central area.

The city's emergency services, Erawan Medical Centre, said at least eight people were killed and more than 20 others were injured.

Footage of the moment of the crash shared on social media showed a line of vehicles had stopped at a railway crossing when a cargo train struck an orange bus.

The impact also dragged several nearby vehicles along



Fire tracks are seen at a train crash site near an airport rail link station in Bangkok, Thailand

the tracks before the bus was engulfed in flames. Several motorcycles and their riders were also seen being thrown onto the road after the collision. Later videos

showed a group of rescuers entering the charred bus after the flames were brought under control.

Deputy Transport Minister Siripong Angkasakulkiat told

reporters at the crash site that all the bodies were found on the bus. He said it was still unclear how many people were on board.

When asked about reports

that the bus had stopped on the railway tracks and that the barriers, used to keep motorists away from the tracks when the trains are passing, may not have lowered properly, Siripong said the matter still needs to be investigated.

Kittipong Raksa said he parked his car near the train tracks when he heard the signal indicating the train was about to pass.

"I heard a thud and then another. I heard something hitting my car," said Kittipong. "Then I saw the train pass, dragging the bus with it." He said after the collision, he found someone caught under his car, with a broken leg. Kittipong said he did not see the barriers being lowered.

Unknown assailants kill two security officials in northwest Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

Unidentified gunmen killed two security personnel in northwest Pakistan on Saturday, police said.

The incident occurred in the Tank district of restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, according to the police. The attackers opened fire at the security personnel of the Federal Constabulary (FC) who were off duty. The attackers managed to flee from the scene, police added. The victims succumbed to their injuries on the spot, while security forces launched a search operation in the area following the attack. Earlier



on Thursday, nine Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) militants and four security officials were killed in a gunfight in Bajaur district, officials said.

No group has claimed responsibility for this attack; however, the Pakistan

Government accuses the banned terror outfit TTP of carrying out attacks on civilians as well as Government infrastructure, especially in provinces bordering Afghanistan, after its ceasefire deal ended in November 2022.

Global warming is causing rivers to slowly lose oxygen, threatening fish and other lives: Study

SETH BORENSTEINAP
■ Washington

Global warming is causing rivers to slowly lose oxygen, threatening fish and other lives in the waterways, a new study shows.

Researchers in China used satellites and artificial intelligence to track and analyse oxygen levels in more than 21,000 rivers across the globe since 1985.

They found oxygen levels have dropped an average of 2.1 per cent since 1985, according to a study published Friday in *Science Advances*. That doesn't seem like much but it adds up and if it continues or accelerates, rivers in the Eastern United States, India and across the tropics could lose enough oxygen by the end of the



century to suffocate some fish and create dead zones, the study said.

Basic chemistry and physics dictate that warmer water holds less oxygen, scientists said.

Warmer water, which happens with human-caused climate change, releases more oxygen into the atmosphere.

If the oxygen loss rate contin-

ues at the current pace, the world's rivers on average will lose an additional 4 per cent of their oxygen by the end of the century, and in some cases close to 5 per cent, the study found. That's when oxygen loss - called deoxygenation - becomes problematic for fish and people who rely on rivers, according to the study's lead author Qi Guan, an environmental scientist at the Chinese Academy of Sciences in Nanjing.

More dead zones appear

Scientists worry that oxygen levels in rivers could fall so low that dead zones appear, as they have in the Gulf of Mexico, Chesapeake Bay and Lake Erie. Those are areas where fish struggle to breathe and die.

"Deoxygenation is a very slow

process. If we have a long period, the negative impact will attack the river ecosystems," Guan said. "The low level of oxygen can cause a series of ecological crises such as biodiversity decline, water quality degradation and maybe some fish will die."

University of Arizona geoscientist Karl Flessa, who wasn't part of the study, said in an email that losing oxygen in rivers means "a future of more stinky dead zones (hypoxia), especially during heat waves."

Some rivers are in such bad shape that "a small change can tip them into the danger zone," Flessa said. "if your favorite fishing hole gets too warm, oxygen levels will go down and there won't be any fish to catch." Earlier this century, India's heavily polluted Ganges

River was losing oxygen more than 20 times faster than the global average, the study said. Even with moderate-to-high increases in global carbon dioxide emission rates - not the implausible worst-case scenario - rivers in the Eastern United States, the Arctic, India and much of South America are projected to lose about 10 per cent of their oxygen by the end of the century, the analysis showed.

Guan said he worries about tropical rivers especially, such as the Amazon in Brazil. Since 1980, the number of days with dead zone spots in the Amazon rose by nearly 16 days per decade, a study last year found. Hydrology professor Marc Bierkens of Utrecht University in the Netherlands,

said a study he and colleagues did last year showed oxygen stress in the world's rivers increased by 13 days every decade and dead zone occurrences increased by nearly three days a decade since 1980. As the world continues to warm, those numbers should jump even higher, said Bierkens, who didn't participate in the Chinese study.

Guan's study found several reasons for oxygen loss in the world's rivers, including nutrient pollution from fertilizer and urban runoff, along with dam construction, flow and wind issues.

But nearly 63 per cent of the problem is from warmer water, the study found. Duke University ecologist and biogeochemist Emily Bernhardt, who wasn't part of the study said. (AP)



Putin to visit Xi Jinping in Beijing next week: Kremlin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moscow

Russian President Vladimir Putin will meet with Chinese leader Xi Jinping on a two-day trip to Beijing next week, the Kremlin said on Saturday.

The announcement comes less than 24 hours after US President Donald Trump finished his own state visit to China, where he also met Xi to discuss trade and the US-Israel war in Iran.

In a statement, the Kremlin said that Putin's trip, planned for May 19-20, had been scheduled to coincide with the 25th anniversary of the 2001 Sino-Russian Treaty of Friendship.

It said that the two leaders would discuss bilateral relations as well as "key international and regional issues" and economic cooperation.

Relations between China and Russia have deepened in recent years, particularly since the start of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in early 2022, which left Moscow shunned on the global stage and heavily reliant on Beijing for trade due to Western sanctions. When Putin visited China in September 2025, Xi welcomed his counterpart as an "old friend." Putin also addressed Xi as "dear friend." The Russian leader is also scheduled to visit China for the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in November.

Continued strikes and returned remains

Ukraine repatriated the bodies of fallen soldiers on Saturday following an earlier



exchange with Moscow involving prisoners of war. Russia returned 528 bodies that "according to the Russian side, may belong to Ukrainian servicemen," Ukraine's Coordination Headquarters for the Treatment of Prisoners of War said in a statement.

Experts will now "take all necessary measures aimed at identifying the deceased who have been repatriated," it said. It comes after Russia and Ukraine swapped 205 prisoners of war on Friday.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said it was the first phase of a planned swap of 1,000 POWs from each side. Some of the Ukrainians had been held by Russia since 2022 and fought in some of the war's fiercest battles, he added. Meanwhile, Russia

launched overnight drone attacks against Ukraine's southern Odesa region on Saturday, regional authorities said. Russian drones struck a five-story apartment block and a one-story residential building, injuring two people, said regional head Oleh Kiper. The city's port was also damaged, he added.

Russia launched 294 drones overnight, Ukraine's Air Force said, adding that 269 of them were shot down.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said that its forces shot down 138 Ukrainian drones overnight over 14 Russian regions, including Moscow. Drones were also destroyed over the annexed Ukrainian peninsula of Crimea, as well as the Black and Azov seas, it said.



This image released by the Maldives President's Media Division, shows divers preparing to search for the four missing Italian divers near Alimathaa Island, Vaavu Atoll, Maldives

Maldivian diver dies during rescue search

KRISHAN FRANCIS ■ Colombo

A Maldivian military diver died on Saturday while searching for the bodies of four Italian divers believed to be deep inside an underwater cave.

The group of five Italian divers is believed to have died while exploring a cave at a depth of about 50 metres in Vaavu Atoll on Thursday, according to Italy's Foreign Ministry. The recreational diving limit in the Maldives is 30 metres.

Maldives Presidential Spokesman Mohammed Hussain Shareef said that Mohamed Mahudhee, a member of the Maldivian National Defence Force, died of underwater decompression sickness after being transferred to a hospital in the capital. "The death goes to show the difficulty of the mission," he said. Earlier,

Shareef said the searchers had prepared a plan based on their progress exploring the cave on Friday.

Rough weather has repeatedly hampered rescue efforts. The Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani said everything possible would be done to bring the victims home.

His ministry stated it was coordinating with Divers Alert Network, a specialist diving organisation, to support recovery operations and the repatriation of the bodies. The victims have been identified as Monica Mentealfalcone, an associate professor of ecology at the University of Genoa; her daughter, Georgia Sommacal; marine biologist Federico Gualtieri; researcher Muriel Oddenino; and diving instructor Gianluca Benedetti, according to the Maldivian Government. (AP)

IS leader killed in joint US-Nigerian mission, says Trump

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

US and Nigerian forces killed a leader of the Islamic State group in Nigeria mission US President Donald Trump said.

Trump announced the joint operation in Africa's most populous country in a late-night social media post that offered few details. He said Abu Bakr al-Mainuki was second-in-command of the Islamic State group globally and "thought he could hide in Africa, but little did he know we had sources who kept us informed on what he was doing".

Al-Mainuki was viewed as the key figure in IS organising and finance, and had been plotting attacks against the United States and its interests, according to an official who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to



President Donald Trump arriving at Joint Base Andrews

share sensitive information. Nigerian President Bola Tinubu confirmed the operation and said Al-Mainuki was killed alongside "several of his lieutenants, during a strike on his compound in the Lake Chad Basin".

According to the spokesperson for the Nigerian military task force that carried out the operation,

the operation was a "highly complex precision air-land operation" and was carried out during three hours of darkness early Saturday without any casualties or loss of assets.

"His elimination represents the single most consequential counterterrorism outcome" in the region since the inception of the operation in 2015, Sani Uba, the spokesperson for the task force, said in a statement.

Born in Nigeria's Borno province in 1982, al-Mainuki took the helm of the IS branch in West Africa after the group's previous leader in the region, Mamman Nur, was killed in 2018, according to the Counter Extremism Project, which tracks militant groups. Al-Mainuki was based in the Sahel area, the monitoring group said, adding that it is believed that he fought in Libya when IS was active in the North African nation more than a decade ago. He was sanctioned by the US in 2023.

Trump, in his social media announcement, said Al-Mainuki was "second in command globally," hiding in Africa, a claim that some analysts say is off the mark. The military, in a statement, also said intelligence shows that

earlier this year, Al-Mainuki might have been "elevated to the position of Head of the General Directorate of States, placing him the second most senior leader within the ISIS hierarchy."

There is no way to verify his position within IS independently. Analysts say Al-Mainuki was the deputy to Abu Musab al-Barnawi, the leader of the Islamic State West African Province who was reported to have died in 2021.

He is regarded as one of the central proponents of the formation of ISWAP, after its split with Boko Haram in 2016. "If confirmed, the killing of Al-Mainuki is huge because this is the first time a security agency has killed someone this high in the ranking of ISWAP," Malik Samuel, a senior researcher at Good Governance Africa who specializes in insurgent groups in Nigeria, said.

North America's largest commuter rail system shuts down as workers strike

PHILIP MARCELO ■ New York

North America's largest commuter rail system was shut down on Saturday after unionised workers in the New York City area went on strike. The Long Island Rail Road that serves the city's eastern suburbs ceased operations early Saturday morning after five unions representing about half its workforce walked off the job.

The two sides have been negotiating for months on a new contract, and President Donald Trump's administration had even interceded to try and broker a deal. But the unions were legally allowed to strike starting at 12.01 am on Saturday. Kevin Sexton of the National Vice President of the Brotherhood of Locomotive Engineers and



Trainmen said no new negotiations have been scheduled.

"We're far apart at this point," Sexton said early Saturday. "We are truly sorry that we are in this situation."

Janno Lieber, the MTA chairman, said the agency "gave the union everything they said they wanted in terms of pay" and that to him it was apparent the unions always intended to walk out.

The walkout, the first for the LIRR since a two-day strike in 1994, promises to cause headaches for some sports fans planning to see the crosstown baseball rivals the New York Yankees and Mets battle this weekend or to watch the NBA's New York Knicks playoff run at Madison Square Garden in Manhattan. Both sports venues have dedicated LIRR stops. (AP)

Pope Leo to visit France in September



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Rome

Pope Leo XIV is adding another trip to his already busy 2026 travel schedule, making a four-day visit to France at the end of September that also includes a visit to the UN culture agency.

The Vatican confirmed Saturday the September 25-28 trip, which will be Leo's fourth foreign voyage of the year: Leo made a day trip to Monaco in March, visited four African nations in April and is due to visit Spain and the Canary Islands in June.

The late Pope Francis famously stayed away from the big European centres of Christianity during his 12-year pontificate, preferring instead to visit small Catholic communities far from Rome.

With the trip to France confirmed, Leo now appears to be paying more attention to the experience of European faithful, amid anecdotal reports of renewed interest in the faith among young adults.

The visit to the UNESCO headquarters will also give Leo the chance to speak to a global audience in a year in which he decided against travelling to his native United States.

US turns to Guyana's bauxite in latest push for Latin America's resources

BERT WILKINSON/CATHERINE BRIGIDA
■ Georgetown

The US announced it is turning its attention toward Guyana's abundant bauxite and other resources for business opportunities at a time when the Trump administration is increasingly eyeing Latin American energy and minerals.

US Under Secretary for Economic Affairs Jacob Helberg held talks this week with top Guyanese officials, including President Irfaan Ali, in the South American country experiencing an oil boom.

The country's mass oil reserves discovered in the last decade have increased Guyana's geopolitical importance, which has only amplified during a global energy crisis caused by the Iran war. Its bauxite reserves are critical for producing aluminum.

The Trump administration has more aggressively focused on Latin America's resources, from pushing to expand oil production in Venezuela following the US military invasion in January, to pursuing cooperation with Brazil over critical minerals. In



a region where energy production seemed to be declining, Latin America is now seeing a reversal of that trend, according to Benjamin Gedan, senior fellow and the director of the Stimson Centre Latin America programme. "In times of global energy scarcity, there's a great deal more focus on Latin America as an alternative stable source of supply," said Gedan. "And Guyana is the leader of that story."

The visit comes amid concerns in the US Government about the Chinese Government and mega companies cashing in on multi-million dollar state contracts at the expense of US companies. (AP)

Pak eyes 100 billion hike in defence budget

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan is expected to raise its defence budget by about PKR 100 billion in the upcoming fiscal year as the Government prepares its budget under an International Monetary Fund (IMF) — backed reform programme that projects a sharp rise in revenues, according to a media report.

The Dawn newspaper, citing the IMF staff report issued after the completion of the third review of the \$7 billion Extended Fund Facility (EFF) and the second review of the \$1.4 billion Resilience and Sustainability Facility (RSF), reported that defence expenditure for 2026-27 was estimated at Pakistani rupees (PKR) Rs 2.665 trillion, up from PKR 2.564 trillion this year.

The IMF projected



Pakistan's total federal revenues for 2026-27 at PKR 17.144 trillion — that's more than PKR 2 trillion higher than the current fiscal year and represents a 13.5 per cent increase, the report said. It said Pakistan had also committed to increasing the combined expenditure of the federal and provincial

Governments by 0.2 per cent of GDP to a total of PKR 4.227 trillion, while digitising all federal and provincial Government payments by June 2027. As part of wider reforms linked to the IMF programme, the Government will identify the 10 top corruption-prone institutions by the end of this

year for detailed analysis and audit. The provincial anti-corruption agencies are also expected to be strengthened. The Government has also given an undertaking not to introduce new incentives for special economic zones, export processing zones, and special technology zones, while phasing out existing incentives by 2035 to create what the report described as a level playing field for all.

The paper said that authorities have maintained that apart from those living in absolute poverty and receiving social income support, around 40 per cent of the population remained economically vulnerable. An IMF staff mission is currently in Pakistan to finalise budget proposals before the budget 2026-27 is presented to the cabinet and the parliament early next month. (PTI)

Drones from foreign allies fuel rise in Sudan's civilian casualties, say Experts

FATMA KHALED ■ Cairo

Drone warfare has become the deadliest threat to civilians in Sudan's conflict, and both the military and the rival paramilitary Rapid Support Forces are being supplied by a number of countries in the West Asia and beyond, experts say.

"Armed drones have now become by far and away the leading cause of civilian deaths," or over 80 per cent of conflict-related deaths, United Nations human rights chief Volker Turk said this week, calling for measures to prevent their transfer to Sudan.

Drones killed at least 880 civilians between January and April. The war in Sudan began in April 2023 and has killed at least 59,000 people, displaced some 13 million



Large plumes of smoke and fire rising from fuel depot in Port Sudan

FILE PHOTO

and pushed parts of the country into famine.

In recent weeks, the RSF has carried out drone attacks on Khartoum International Airport and other areas near the capital, which the army seized control of last year.

"On the battlefield, drones have emerged as a force multiplier, enabling ground offensives and weakening enemy defences," said Jalale Getachew Birru, East Africa senior analyst at the US-based Armed Conflict Location & Event Data project. Both the army and RSF use drones to secure contested territory, disrupt mobilisation efforts and spread insecurity in areas controlled by rivals, he said.

At least 2,670 people, including combatants and civilians, were killed in 2025, marking a 600 per

cent increase in drone-related deaths and an 81 per cent increase in drone attacks compared to the previous year, ACLED found.

Drone strikes by the warring parties have targeted civilian infrastructure, including hospitals, dams, schools, markets and displacement camps.

Most of the civilian deaths in drone attacks have occurred in the Kordofan region in the central Sudan, according to Turk.

On May 8, drone strikes in South Kordofan and near the city of el-Obeid in North Kordofan reportedly killed 26 civilians. More than 70 people were killed in drone attacks on densely populated areas in Kordofan earlier this year, according to the Sudan Doctors Network. On Tuesday, a Sudanese rights group, the Emergency

Lawyers, said nine drone attacks on civilian vehicles had killed at least 36 people over the past 10 days across seven provinces.

The group blamed both the army and RSF and said some drones use visual monitoring technology capable of distinguishing targets, raising concerns that the attacks may not have been indiscriminate. The paramilitary RFS began only last year to use drones widely, said Gabriella Tejeda, research associate at The Soufan Centre. The army and RSF are competing to obtain new drone models, particularly from China, but the RSF is modifying drones and "increasingly competing to acquire newer, more sophisticated models, with the UAE likely supplying them," Tejeda said. (AP)

BRIEFLY

Rayhan Thomas builds on his solid start



Rayhan Thomas built on his solid start by carding a 3-under 70 to move into the top 15 after the second round of the Colonial Life Charity Classic in Elgin. Thomas now has a total score of 5-under par and is placed T-14 on the leaderboard. Blades Brown (66-66), Trent Phillips (65-67) and Paul Peterson (64-68) became joint leaders by the end of the second round. The trio all had a total score of 8-under par to lead the field by one stroke. First day joint leader Zac Blair (63-70) is in T-4 along with Martin Laird with a total score of 7-under par. Thomas began his second round on the front nine with birdies on the first and second holes. He dropped a stroke on the ninth hole to be 1-under par at the turn. On the back nine, he dropped a stroke on the 13th hole before making consecutive birdies on the 14th and 15th holes. A third bogey on the 16th hole was followed by consecutive birdies on the 17th and 18th holes to close the day with a score of 3-under 67.

Indian golfer Aditi Ashok misses cut in Cincinnati



Indian golfer Aditi Ashok missed the cut at the Kroger Queen City Championship after carding a second round of 1-over 71. Put alongside her round of 2-over on the first day, her total score was 3-over par after the second round, while the cut was set at 2-over par. Amanda Doherty and Jin Young Ko were joint leaders at the end of the second round. Amanda and Jin Young Ko both carded 4-under 66 on the second day to become joint leaders. The leaders have a total score of 7-under par heading into the weekend. Aditi missed the cut for only the third time this season. Her last result was the T-3 finish at the Blue Bay LPGA.

US women train for Olympic sport they had never heard of

JAIME DING
Los Angeles

Rylee White had never even heard of the fast-paced sport of handball until her roommate mentioned a TikTok video about tryouts in Los Angeles for the US Olympic women's team — no experience necessary.

White, a 27-year-old screenwriter, knew she had to go. She wasn't the only one. More than 150 women — buoyed by the viral video — attended the tryouts in January, a five-fold increase from previous turnouts.

Five months later, White is one of a handful of women who have packed their bags and moved to Florida to join USA Handball's national residency program, hoping to eventually be selected to



represent the United States at the 2028 Summer Olympics in Los Angeles.

As the host nation, the US automatically qualifies for every sport.

The last time the United States had a women's handball team at the Games was in 1996. Finding the money and resources needed to

Satwik-Chirag enter Thailand Open final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Bangkok

A gritty Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty showed nerves of steel as they stormed into the men's doubles final with a riveting three-game win over Malaysia's Goh Sze Fei and Nur Izzuddin at the Thailand Open Super 500 badminton tournament on Saturday.

World number 4 Satwik and Chirag, who won the title in 2019 and 2024, displayed remarkable composure under pressure to out-class the world number 9 Malaysian pair 19-21 22-20 21-16 in a gruelling semifinal that lasted 82 minutes. "It feels good. We didn't start the

year off well, we were also not good mentally because of not having a really good start.

"As players, we are very, very driven, and we really wanted some answers, and finally the bronze at the Thomas Cup especially boosted our confidence, and here we are playing our first final of the year," Chirag said.

"Hopefully, we can go and win the title." It will be their third final appearance at the \$500,000 tournament and first of the season.

The Indian pair will have to recover from the 82-minute match when they face Indonesia's Leo Rolly Carnando and Daniel Marthin in the summit clash. The Malaysians made a bright



start, dominating the front-court battle to lead 3-1, but the Indians quickly caught up with some fine finishing to make it 5-5. The match was dominated by lightning-fast rallies, packed with relentless,

angled attacking returns and immaculate defending.

The Malaysians had the nose ahead for most of the first half of the opening game, going into the break with an 11-8 lead. There were some

Senthilkumar, Chinappa win big in HCL National Doubles squash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai

Top seeds Velavan Senthilkumar and Joshna Chinappa produced a superb display to clinch the mixed doubles title at the 3rd HCL National Doubles Squash Championships in Chennai on Saturday.

The top-seeded pair defeated the second-seeded duo of Abhay Singh and Rathika Seelan 11-7, 11-9 in a closely fought final at the Indian Squash Academy.

Earlier in the tournament, both Senthilkumar and Joshna had also captured the men's and women's doubles crowns, respectively, with their partners. Senthilkumar teamed



up with Abhay to secure the men's doubles title for a third consecutive year after beating second seeds Rahul Baitra and Suraj Kumar Chand 11-8,

11-5 in the final.

In the women's doubles final, Joshna and Rathika out-classed Janet Vidhi and Pooja Arthi 11-8, 11-4 to lift the title.

Manchester City beats Chelsea 1-0 in FA Cup final

ASSOCIATED PRESS
London

In its 155-year history the FA Cup final can rarely have been won by a more audacious goal. Manchester City beat Chelsea 1-0 at Wembley Stadium on Saturday thanks to a moment of magic from Antoine Semenyo.

The forward brought to life a final that had produced little in the way of chances or excitement with a spectacular back-heeled goal in the second half. Running onto a cross from Erling Haaland in the 72nd minute, Semenyo flicked his heel at the ball and directed it low into the far corner past diving Chelsea goalkeeper Robert Sanchez. Victory kept City in the hunt for a domestic trophy treble, having already won the English League Cup.

Pep Guardiola's team is also second in the Premier League, two points behind Arsenal with two rounds to go. This was Guardiola's 17th major trophy



in 10 years at City and his 35th in his career overall.

City has won the Cup eight times and moved level with Chelsea, Liverpool and Tottenham as equal third on the

all-time winners' list. Defeat means Chelsea will end the season trophyless — a year after being crowned Club World Cup champion - in what has been a crisis-ridden campaign.



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Girona (Spain)

India's Veer Ahlawat and Saptak Talwar made an early exit as the duo missed the cut at the Challenge de Catalunya.

Ahlawat carded a bogey-free second round of 4-under 69 following a first round even par 71, but still missed out. Talwar, who shot 86 on day one, carded 1-under 71, but it did not help me make the cut. The cut this week was set at 5-under par. Christofer Bloomstrand carded the low score of the day, an 8-under 64 to move into the lead with a total score of 13-under par (67-64).

Avani cards second lowest score to make cut in Germany



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Hamburg (Germany)

Avani Prashanth emerged as the lone Indian to make the cut at the Amundi German Masters after producing an impressive four-under 69 in the second round to climb to 1-over par overall.

Avani, playing in only her second season as a professional on the Ladies European Tour, carded the joint second-lowest round to climb to tied-47th and safely make the cut, which fell at 2-over par.

The two other Indians in the field, Pranavi Urs and Vani Kapoor, failed to make the weekend after missing the cut. Pranavi returned a second-round card of 1-over par to finish at 4-over overall in tied-72nd place, while Vani retired after the opening round. Avani, meanwhile, enjoyed a much-improved second round after starting on the front nine.

The turnaround was evident early as she eagled the par-5 fourth hole, having

endured a double bogey on the same hole in the opening round. She carried the momentum into the back nine with birdies on the 11th and 13th holes before dropping her lone shot of the round on the 14th. A late birdie on the 17th capped off an impressive day as Avani signed off with a 4-under 69.

Home favourite Esther Henseleit is leading the field with a score of 9-under par (64-71) after carding a second round 2-under 71. Esther made five birdies and three bogeys in her second round.

Sara Kousskova shot the lowest round of the day. She fired a 7-under 64 to move into second position with a total score of 8-under par (71-64).

The two-time LET winner began her round on the 10th hole and produced an early moment of brilliance by holing out from a bunker for eagle on the very next hole. She added birdies on the 14th and 17th before catching fire on the front nine with three successive birdies on the third, fourth and fifth holes.

Aryaveer Dewan to lead India at Asian Junior Squash in China

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai

Aryaveer Dewan will spearhead India's challenge at the Asian Junior Individual Squash Championships to be held in Panzhihua, China, later this month.

Dewan, who clinched the U-17 boys' title last year, will move up to the U-19 category this time and enter the tournament, scheduled from May 20 to 24, as the third seed.

India will field a 32-member contingent across the U-11 to U-19 categories and will aim to better its seven-medal haul.



Mourinho receives Arbeloa's blessing amid talk of return to Madrid

JOSEPH WILSON
Barcelona (Spain)

Real Madrid's Alvaro Arbeloa gave his blessing to former boss Jose Mourinho on Saturday amid intense speculation that the Portuguese coach is set to replace him and start a second stint at the European powerhouse.

Speaking like a coach who knows his days are numbered, Arbeloa told reporters in Madrid on Saturday that "if he (Mourinho) is the one who is here next season, I will be happy to see him back home." Arbeloa played for Madrid when Mourinho was in charge from 2010-2013, a tumultuous time in which Madrid won the Spanish



league and Copa del Rey titles but was overshadowed by Pep Guardiola's great Barcelona side. Mourinho's abrasive attitude to opponents like Guardiola, as well as some of his own players,

turned off many in Spain. He also had his faithful backers, like Arbeloa and some hardcore fans.

The Madrid sports papers are rife with rumours that Mourinho is the leading can-

didate to replace Arbeloa, who was always seen as an interim coach after he was promoted from the club's reserve team midseason to fill in for the fired Xabi Alonso.

Second-place Madrid has two more Spanish league games to play this campaign, which it will finish without a major title. It visits Sevilla on Sunday and concludes the season at home against Athletic Bilbao on May 23.

The 15-time European Cup winners have been embarrassed in recent weeks by a series of unseemly events. There was a fight between players, and a loss at Barcelona that allowed its fierce rival to clinch the league title. Kylian Mbappe

was also jeered by fans, while the star striker called out Arbeloa publicly for not playing him more.

Club president Florentino Perez added to the sense of a club in crisis by giving a press conference to announce he would call early elections, which he is expected to win, while blasting the media for what he considered a campaign to force him to quit. Perez is expected to make a coaching change soon, and, understandably, he believes Mourinho's strong personality is what the squad needs.

Mourinho, who led Porto and Inter Milan to Champions League titles in 2004 and 2010, is finishing his season with Benfica this weekend. (AP)



Allen, Raghuvanshi, Green power KKR to 29-run win over GT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Finn Allen blasted a 35-ball 93, while Angkrish Raghuvanshi hit an unbeaten 44-ball 82 as Kolkata Knight Riders kept their playoff hopes alive with a 29-run win over Gujarat Titans in the IPL match on Saturday. Sent in to bat, Allen went on a six-hitting spree, smashing 10 maximums and four boundaries to add 95 off 41 balls with Raghuvanshi (82). Raghuvanshi then shared another 108 off 53 balls with Cameron Green (52 not out) to power KKR to a challenging 247 for 2.

In reply, GT could manage 218-4, riding on skipper Shubman Gill's 49-ball 85 and a 35-ball 57 from Jos

Buttler. Opener Sai Sudarsan was retired hurt but returned to make a 28-ball 53 not out. Sunil Narine (2/29) claimed two wickets and Saurabh Dubey snapped one for KKR. For GT, Mohammed Siraj (1/50), Sai Kishore (1/38) were the wicket-takers.

The explosive New Zealand opener made GT pay dearly for dropping him on 14 and 33, smashing 10 sixes and four boundaries in a breathtaking assault where 86 runs came through boundaries.

If Allen ripped apart the bowling in the first half, Angkrish Raghuvanshi (82 not out) and Cameron Green (52 not out) maintained the momentum with unbeaten fifties in their 108-run stand off just 53 balls for the third



doing well in their must-win match. He survived a difficult chance on 14 when the tall Jason Holder got fingertips to a sharp opportunity at cover off Mohammed Siraj.

The Kiwi opener then tore into Kagiso Rabada, launching successive sixes — one straight over mid-off and another whipped over mid-wicket off a 149kph delivery — to race to 28 from just 11 balls. While Allen dominated from one end, Ajinkya Rahane never quite settled during his scratchy 14 off 14 balls before Siraj cleaned him up.

There was a brief slow-down inside the powerplay after Rahane's departure before Allen got another life. Introduced into the attack, Holder induced a mishit from

the batter, but Siraj spilled a straightforward catch at long-on. From there, Allen went into overdrive. He attacked both pace and spin with equal ease, picking lengths early and clearing the boundaries effortlessly.

Rashid was welcomed with two sixes and a four as Allen stormed to a 21-ball half-century. Raghuvanshi played the ideal supporting role. The young batter used the pace cleverly and kept the scoreboard ticking, including a sharp scoop over the wicket-keeper off Rabada to get going.

Allen looked set for a second IPL hundred this season before Rashid finally ended the carnage, taking a well-judged catch at deep midwicket off Sai Kishore.

Fatima Sana to lead Pakistan squad for Women's T20 WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Fatima Sana will continue to lead Pakistan, which will have five players set to make their maiden appearance in next month's Women's T20 World Cup in England and Wales.

The selectors announced Pakistan's 15-member squad on Saturday, which will also take part in a triangular T20I series in Ireland before the T20 World Cup.

The West Indies will be the third team in the tri-series.

Eyman Fatima, Natalia Pervaiz, Rameen Shamim, Saira Jabeen and Tasmia Rubab are the players bound for their first appearance in



the T20 World Cup. Pakistan will take on India in their tournament opener on June 14 at Birmingham.

The tri-series will be played in Dublin from May 28 to June 4, following which Pakistan will take on Sri Lanka on June 6 and Scotland on June 9 in the two warm-up matches before the 12-team T20 World Cup.

Signature celebration fuels motivation: Akash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Pacer Akash Singh caught the eye with his unique celebration during Lucknow Super Giants' win over Chennai Super Kings, pulling out a piece of paper from his pocket after a wicket, a gesture he said was aimed at "motivating" himself and "asserting dominance" over batters.

Left-arm pacer pulled out a scrappy piece of paper after each of the three wickets he took in LSG's seven-wicket win over CSK, with the message reading: "Akki knows how to take wickets in T20 cricket. The 24-year-old, who began his IPL journey with



Rajasthan Royals and was part of Chennai Super Kings' title-winning campaign in 2023 before moving to Lucknow Super Giants, registered his best IPL figures with 3 for 26 on Friday.

"Akki knows how to take wickets in T20 cricket, right?" Akash said when asked about the message on the piece of paper, adding that it serves as a source of motivation and helps him focus on dominating batters and delivering stronger performances for the team.

"Different things motivate different people. Some days I show the paper, some days I don't, but it reflects my mindset on that particular day. When you carry a piece of paper with something

the strong backing from the Lucknow Super Giants support staff over the last two years and the most important thing has been the backing from the coaches, even when I'm not in the playing XI. This year we have Bharat Arun sir, last year Zaheer sir was there...Tom Moody. The way they guide us, prepare us and keep us ready for opportunities is very important when there are 25 players in the squad," he said.

"When you are not playing, you naturally seek backing, and every player wants to make the most of the opportunities he gets.

RCB out to seal play-off berth, Punjab Kings to arrest freefall



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dharamsala

Royal Challengers Bengaluru would look to exploit vulnerabilities of a profligate Punjab Kings bowling line-up to seal a play-off berth in the Indian Premier League in Dharamsala on Sunday.

In the only day game scheduled at the scenic Dharamsala stadium, the top draw without an iota of doubt is Virat Kohli, fresh off a hundred in the previous game. A sizeable number of fans have already made their way up to the mountains from Delhi and Punjab to see the larger than life Kohli bat in the breathtaking backdrop of the Dhauladhar range. The limited infrastructure in place in the city is pushed to its limits.

Defending champions, the only team which has maintained consistency throughout the tournament, are clear favourites against Punjab Kings, who are in a freefall, having lost five games in a row after being the most dominant team in the first half

of the tournament.

While RCB are sitting comfortably on the points table, a sixth loss for Punjab Kings would effectively shut the playoff door on the Shreyas Iyer-led side.

In both the games played here, the Punjab Kings failed to defend 210 and 200 after failing to control the last five overs. In fact, they have lost the most number of games (10) after posting 200-plus total in the format's history.

The team needs to rejig its bowling combination, with the likes of Xavier Bartlett and Marco Jansen proving expensive throughout the tournament. Arshdeep Singh has managed to bring his economy rate under 10 with his frugal returns in the last game, while Azmatullah Omarzai made an immediate impact with bat and ball in his first game of the season.

Vijaykumar Vyshak has been out of the side, and perhaps the team goes back to him in search of much-needed control in the middle and death overs.

Jasprit Bumrah to play only one format against Afghanistan

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Jasprit Bumrah will either play the one-off Test or the three-match ODI series against Afghanistan next month as the national selection committee is keeping an eye on the pace spearhead's workload while naming the squads for the series on May 19.

The one-off Test, which isn't a part of the World Test Championship cycle, will be played at New Chandigarh from June 6-10, while the three ODIs will be held on June 14 (Dharamsala), 17 (Lucknow) and 20 (Chennai) respectively.

The bilateral ODIs have gained traction because that is the only format in which Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma



play internationally. However, Delhi speedster Prince Yadav's name will certainly be discussed by the selection committee, considering his stellar show in the last edition of the national one-day championship. Prince took 17 wickets from 8 Vijay Hazare Trophy games.

Besides that, his effort in the ongoing IPL 2026, 16 wickets from 12 games, including the dismissal of Virat Kohli with a lovely seaming delivery, has underlined the fact that there couldn't be a better series to try out Prince, since Harshit Rana is unlikely to get fit anytime soon.

No experiment with Test squad: It can be said with a degree of certainty that the selection committee led by

Ajit Agarkar is not going to experiment with the red ball format squad.

The tried and tested faces in the past one year are expected to fill the squad with an eye on the away series against Sri Lanka and New Zealand, where contrasting conditions could be on offer.

While Bumrah has had a hectic IPL, it is unlikely that he will skip the entire two-week series starting June 6. For someone who takes pride in wearing the India Whites, whether Bumrah will be required for a lone Test against Afghanistan is the moot point.

As per sources, if he plays the Test match, he wouldn't take part in the three-match ODI series. In case he plays the ODI series, then he would be rested for the Test match. While there has been a lot of talk about changes in the squad, in all likelihood, Devdutt Padikkal, who was also a part of the team that was thrashed by South Africa last year, might replace Sai Sudharsan at No. 3 in the batting line-up. The other options for that slot will be Washington Sundar, who has batted at No. 3 for Tamil Nadu and Dhruv Jurel as a specialist batter.

In case Bumrah doesn't play, the new ball attack is likely to be headlined by Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh

Krishna. With both Akash Deep and Harshit injured, Jammu and Kashmir seamer Auqib Nabi, who took 60 wickets in the last Ranji Trophy season, might be the reserve pacer. But his fight is against pace bowling all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy.

If Bumrah plays, then Nabi might have to wait for his turn, as not more than three frontline fast bowlers would be picked for a Test match in India, where spinners call the shots.

In case of spinners, Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav and Washington are automatic choices. From the squad that was picked against South Africa, Axar Patel's place could be under the scanner in the longest format. (PTI)

CSK would have learnt a lot from LSG loss: Ravi Shastri

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

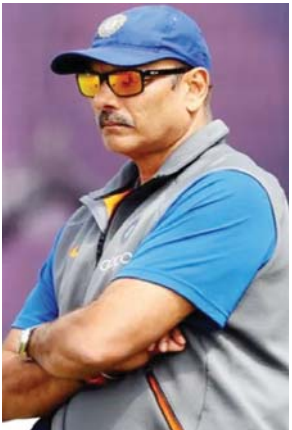
Cricketer-turned-commentator Ravi Shastri reckons Chennai Super Kings would have learnt some hard lessons from their seven-wicket defeat to Lucknow Super Giants, but backed the five-time champions to bounce back strongly in their final two league matches to keep their playoff hopes alive.

CSK's playoff aspirations suffered a massive blow after LSG comfortably chased down a competitive 187, leaving the Chennai outfit in a virtual must-win situation heading into the business end of the IPL league stage.

"I would take the positives from this game for CSK. I'd think that this wicket wasn't that easy and, despite batting first, they still made 187. Sanju Samson didn't score runs, Ruturaj Gaikwad didn't get many either, so if they find form (in the upcoming matches), that should be key for CSK," said Shastri on JioHotstar.

"Their bowlers will learn what lengths they need to bowl in conditions like these. In Chennai, they know what works and where to bowl, so they will be a much stronger team at home. They will also have their plans ready for that surface. So, I would look at this as an off day, but also as a game that offered plenty of lessons," he added.

With Anshul Kamboj enduring an expensive outing and conceding 63 runs in 2.4 overs, CSK struggled to contain LSG despite condi-



tions offering assistance to the pacers on a surface that was not entirely batting-friendly. Shastri said Kamboj should have shown better awareness and targeted yorkers in the blockhole, which might have prevented Mitchell Marsh from smashing him for four sixes.

"After getting hit for four sixes, what should Anshul Kamboj have done? In my opinion, he should have thought more about bowling yorkers, targeting the stumps right in the blockhole.

"When you know Marsh was waiting for anything short of a length, either bowl yorkers at the stumps or, if you're bowling bouncers, bowl them outside the off stump with a deep third man in place.

"Bend your back and bowl them closer to head height, not at chest or waist height, because that is bread and butter for someone who has grown up playing in Perth. It becomes very easy for him to use the pace," opined Shastri.

20-30% increase in IPL media rights will not be surprising: Mohit Burman

BHARAT SHARMA
■ Dharamsala

Punjab Kings co-owner Mohit Burman believes the recent winning bids for two IPL franchises worth billions of dollars will have a positive impact on the next media rights cycle, and an increase of 20-30 per cent will not surprise him.

The existing media rights cycle from 2023-2027 fetched an eye-popping Rs 48,000 crore (roughly \$6.2 billion as per the exchange rate back then).

While the number for television rights could go down, the digital rights value is expected to go up drastically. Rajasthan Royals and Royal Challengers Bengaluru



recently attracted successful bids from new investors for close to \$2 billion each (\$1.65 billion and \$1.78 billion, respectively), and Burman said that is bound to drive up the media rights value.

"It would be speculative to put an exact number on it right now because the media industry itself is evolving very quickly. The dynamics between television and digital are changing every year, and consumer behaviour is shifting rapidly toward mobile and streaming-first consumption," Burman said.

Burman termed the engagement consistency of IPL as a big confidence booster. "But what gives confidence is the IPL's consistency. Very few sports prop-

erties globally deliver this level of engagement year after year. It continues to attract advertisers, massive audiences and strong digital traction. "So while growth rates may not always be linear, the long-term trajectory for the IPL remains extremely strong. A 20-30 per cent increase in the media rights cycle would

not be surprising," said Burman, who holds a 48 per cent stake in Punjab Kings. According to Burman, the global investor interest and the investment attracted by teams put the IPL in the same league as the NFL, EPL and NBA.

"These valuations are not built only on current revenues, but on the long-term potential of the league as a sports and entertainment property. IPL today is among the world's premier sporting leagues in terms of engagement, reach and commercial value, so naturally the market is recognising that.

"Investors today are looking at IPL not only as a cricket tournament but as a long-term sports, media and entertain-

ment asset. What is especially significant is that these valuations are now being benchmarked against global sporting leagues. Earlier, Indian sports properties were largely valued in isolation.

"Today, IPL franchises are being spoken about in the same breath as teams from leagues like the NBA, EPL and NFL. That shift itself is a huge statement about the IPL's global standing," said Burman, who is also the Chairman of Dabur India.

Burman feels there is a strong link between valuations of teams and media rights. "There is definitely a psychological and commercial linkage between franchise valuations and media rights valuations. (PTI)

Sooryavanshi faces Starc test as Delhi Capitals take on Royals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's audacious strokeplay will come up against seam-and-swing master Mitchell Starc as Rajasthan Royals and Delhi Capitals lock horns in a high-stakes IPL "Sunday Suspense" clash with playoff hopes hanging by a thread.

While DC's qualification chances (10 points from 12 games) are already slim, a defeat would officially knock them out of the playoff race.

For the Royals (12 points from 11 games), the week-long break is expected to have rejuvenated the squad. They would not want DC to play party poopers and allow Punjab Kings (13 points from

12 games) to breathe easy.

No teenager since the genius Sachin Tendulkar has captured the public imagination quite like the schoolboy from Samastipur in Bihar, who already boasts a sizeable fan base.

His 'Capital Debut' at the Ferozeshah Kotla is no less than the cricketing equivalent of a 'Met Gala' with the who's who of NCR clamouring for free passes.

Delhi Capitals' fan base remains something of a paradox in the IPL's 19 years of existence. When Royal Challengers Bengaluru play at the Kotla, the crowd rallies behind Virat Kohli, while the arrival of Chennai Super Kings turns the stands canary yellow, with jerseys bearing



the iconic number 7 of MS Dhoni dominating the scene.

Having failed to build an organic fan base, it is hardly surprising that fans queuing up at the Kotla turnstiles would be there to watch their chubby-cheeked hero in the flesh for the first time.

But amid this hype, the sub-plot that will intrigue one and all would be how Starc can stop a marauding Sooryavanshi, who has hit 40 sixes in 11 games while scoring 440 runs at a stunning strike-rate of 236.55.

Over the years, Starc has blown hot and cold during IPL seasons. There have been matches where he has been taken to the cleaners by unheralded Indian batters, and there have been

matches like the 2024 IPL final, when he set up KKR's title win with the most memorable opening spell in nearly two decades.

One wouldn't know which Starc would turn up this Sunday, but if it is the 'Test bowler' Mitchell Starc, then Sooryavanshi will have some really tough problems to solve. If the Aussie veteran, with more than 400 Test victims, gets early seam and swing, it will be a test of Sooryavanshi's technique, as the teenager's game is more about hand-eye coordination than footwork.

Of late, DC have been playing on tracks which aren't exactly very high scoring, but the lack of bite in their international spin

attack, comprising skipper Axar Patel (10 wickets from 12 games) and Kuldeep Yadav (7 wickets from 11 games), has been the problem.

Neither has the duo been penetrative nor restrictive enough, which has proved to be a bane for Team Delhi.

The pace attack save Lungi Ngidi has looked pedestrian, especially the Indian bowlers like T Natarajan (ER of 11.18) and Mukesh Kumar (ER 10.67), who could once again get thrashed by Sooryavanshi, Yashasvi Jaiswal and Dhruv Jurel.



Your Ride History



This International Museum Day, on May 18, at the National Rail Museum, century-old locomotives stand as silent witnesses to India's industrial transformation, demanding your presence to truly feel their monumental weight, writes SAKSHI PRIYA



What happens to the machines that built a country when they become obsolete? Ten acres of open gravel answer that question in hundred ton blocks of resting cast iron. When steam power entered the landscape, it forced a sprawling landmass into a single synchronized schedule. The National Rail Museum stands as the physical residue of that massive shift.

Inside the administrative offices, Director Dinesh Kumar Goyal views the yard as an anchor against historical amnesia. "Museum are more than repositories of the past — they are bridges to our future," Goyal states. "At the National Rail Museum, we preserve the legacy of India's railway journey, celebrate the spirit of innovation and connect generations through stories that continue to inspire."

Out on the tracks sits the F-734. Built in 1895 at the Ajmer Workshop, it holds the record as the first locomotive manufactured entirely on Indian soil. Before its construction, engines arrived in wooden crates from Britain to be bolted together at Jamalpur. By the time the F-734 reached this yard decades later, the

nineteen ton machine was rotting into red dust. Bringing a dead machine back from the rust is not a delicate process. It takes months of brute, manual work. Mechanics grind away the corroded iron by hand, torch fresh steel into the gaps, and seal the bare metal under thick coats of red oxide primer.

Further down the line rest the veterans of strange geographies and forgotten conflicts. The Decauville Primrose looks impossibly narrow. Engineers designed this track system to be taken apart and hauled up mountain passes on the backs of elephants. During the Frontier Wars against Afghan tribes, it performed the heavy lifting of a thousand camels. Not far away sits the B-777 of the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway. The public charm of the mountain toy train hides a history of human risk and constant fear. To conquer the steep Himalayan gradients, a worker had to hang off the outside footboard while the engine moved. He manually threw handfuls of sand onto the rails so the wheels could find a grip in the cold. Then came the WDM1. Resting quietly across the path, this blunt nosed



PRESERVING HERITAGE



Historic black steam locomotive displayed under an outdoor museum shed



A vintage green royal saloon at National Rail Museum



A glimpse into India's remarkable railway evolution

American diesel arrived in 1957. It killed the steam era, slashed travel times, and quietly erased thousands of coal shoveling jobs.

Keeping these machines intact is an unglamorous, daily fight against oxidation. Assistant Director Gopal Singh manages the immediate fallout of this decay. Almost every major exhibit here is over a hundred years old. Singh relies on active Indian Railway workshops for heavy maintenance. Mechanics forge them by hand or salvage them from scrap.

Reading about historical cast iron on a page cannot replicate the sheer physical weight of standing in its shadow. This International Museum Day look directly at the physical evidence of the past. History is never a neat narrative printed in a textbook. It is an accumulation of grease, rusted rivets, and cold steel. To understand the exact speed of the modern world, a person needs to walk the gravel and stand next to the heavy, silent machines that first started the clock.

THE OUTDOOR TOY TRAIN RIDE TAKES PASSENGERS ON A TRACK LOOPING PAST VARIOUS HISTORIC STEAM LOCOMOTIVES AND VINTAGE HERITAGE DISPLAYS

Beat the frizz



TEAM VIVA

Weekends are for a proper cup of tea, completely uninterrupted. You absolutely should not spend your morning fighting a hair-brush through a dry, tangled mess. We completely ignore the skin covering our heads until it starts itching uncontrollably. Ultraviolet light pierces straight into the hair shaft to break down the keratin holding everything together. Your colour fades away and the strands end up feeling exactly like dry straw. Then the humidity arrives. The heavy, muggy air forces your hair cuticles to swell up repeatedly until they completely lose the capacity to hold any moisture.

Wandering down the beauty aisles, you face countless bottles promising a quick summer miracle. "The effectiveness of a summer haircare product depends more on formulation science than on marketing claims," explains Melissa Hughe, Technical and Education Director at Beauty Garage Limited. It lives completely and unapologetically in what is listed on the back.

Water-soluble silicones offer genuine and measurable UV protec-

tion without the dense, suffocating residue that older traditional formulations tend to leave behind on every strand. They work through ionic bonding, physically attaching to negatively charged damaged fibres and smoothing them from within.

Antioxidant-rich shampoos, niacinamide for an inflamed and overworked scalp, bond-repair treatments that reach deep into the cortex and rebuild what heat has methodically undone, these are a straight-forward and evidence-based response to what summer genuinely inflicts on hair month after relentless month. Armed with the right ingredients, you can walk into the heat feeling entirely like yourself. Are you checking your labels this season?

YOUR BATHROOM SHELF HAS BEEN SOLVING SUMMER HAIR PROBLEMS FOREVER



ART CORNER

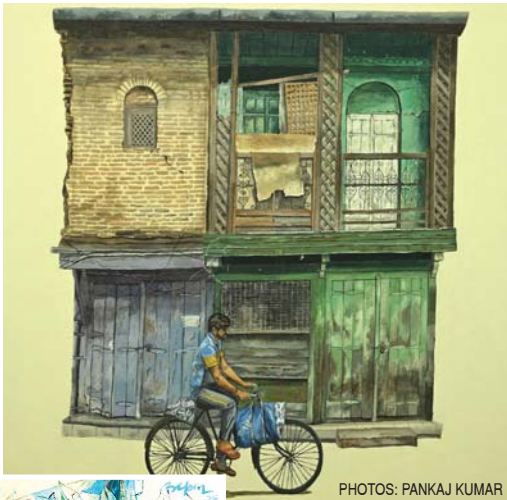
Finding a language for the unspoken

Generations collide, styles unfurl, and art finds its unspoken voice

SAKSHI PRIYA

Art history often behaves like a locked vault, archiving voices by age and market value. *The Contemporary Lore: Sojourn of Styles and Generations Unfurled*, presented by Shailja Art Gallery at Bikaner House, shatters this stagnant hierarchy. The exhibition stages a visceral, living conversation among 23 artists across generations, stripping away the labels of 'emerging' and 'master' to champion a landscape built entirely on artistic rigor and raw truth.

Anil Gaikwad's acrylic canvas, *Dream*, immediately pulls viewers through the abstract, layered stages of slumber, creating an ethereal plane of pure imagination. Nearby, the stripped-down struggle of human survival breathes through Ashok Bhowmik's *Fowlers*. His subjects rise above their roles as literal bird catchers to become harbingers of revolutionary hope. The conversation shifts inward as Asit Patnaik examines the soul's intimate dualities in *The World Within*, revealing fluid gender dynamics where a male reflection cradles the female self in deep meditation. Bharti Prapatti then roots the narrative in indigenous visual languages with *Earth Story* — *Water*, balancing the geometric rusticity of tribal aesthetics with the dual elemental



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



nature of womanhood.

Moving deeper into the space, the heavy emotional weight of the unsaid takes physical form. Yusuf brings a quiet, intellectual clarity to the walls, relying on minimalist lines and spatial balance to map the geometry of the hole left behind when society turns away. His canvases refuse easy answers, vibrating with the silent tension of fear and pain over conventional aesthetic comfort. Moving through the space, you eventually stand before the work of Shaji Apukuttan, and the room seems to hold its breath. Apukuttan refuses to treat a landscape as pure background scenery. His canvases refuse the easy trap of beauty, capturing instead an earth that is visibly bruised and actively straining. The land shifts, bruises, buckles. Human ambition sits heavy on it. The damage is quiet. That's what makes it hard to look away.

Curated by Kiran K Mohan, with critical framing by Johny ML, this showcase breaks down the usual gallery walls. Catch it before it closes to feel the living currents of modern Indian art.

MANGO me crazy...

SAKSHI PRIYA

Nobody really says no to mango. Not here, not in this heat. The afternoon comes down hard on the city every year around this time, and you learn quickly enough to stop fighting it. You find shade, you slow down, you wait. And somewhere in that waiting, the markets fill up crates stacked high before dawn, that particular smell reaching you halfway down the street before your eyes even find the stall. Summer suddenly has a point again. There is an old saying most

MATCHA MEETS ITS MATCH

The Mango Iced Matcha makes no promises, just earthy green tea folded into cold tropical juice, and somehow by the bottom of the glass, the heat has stopped mattering quite so much



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

people in this country grew up hearing at least once - *aam ke aam, guthliyon ke daam*. Every last thing wrung from this fruit, nothing wasted, nothing left on the stone. We take it seriously. We always have. The pulp goes into the blender with whatever ice remains and you drink it down before it has a chance to melt.

Barista, this year, decided to meet that instinct somewhere in the middle. Their new seasonal menu, *Main Hoon Mango - Jab aam bhi khaas ban jaaye*, does not try to reinvent anything so much as quietly complicate it, in the best possible way. The *Chilli Mango Tango* catches you off guard. You expect sweetness and you get it, briefly, then the chilli hits the back of the throat, sharp and unhurried, and the whole drink changes entirely. It is genuinely surprising in a season when very little is.

The *Mango Iced Espresso* is for people who have already given up on the afternoon but are not quite ready to admit it. Coffee over cold mango, two things that have no obvious business together, and yet somewhere in that glass they sort each other out completely. You drink it and somehow find yourself ready to go again.

The *Mango Matcha* is quieter, earthy, smooth, easy to drink, while the *Dirty Mango*

This summer, your most familiar mango habit just got a whole lot more interesting. The only question now is, are you in or are you out?

Latte ignores the rulebook entirely, espresso dropped into a thick creamy mango base, rich and slightly reckless, and all the more enjoyable for it.

What a slice decision with the *Mango Cheesecake Cold*, dense, properly buttery at the base where it matters most, and that mango sitting on top is doing real work. You eat one slice and immediately start doing the quiet mental math on whether a second one is entirely unreasonable.

Pull up a chair somewhere cool. Let the city burn at its own pace outside. Order everything once, then decide what deserves a second round. Have a mango-licious day.



MANGO IS HAVING A MOMENT

Mango with espresso. Mango with chilli. Mango stirred into matcha. Combinations that look questionable on paper, yet somehow make complete sense once you actually taste them. Someone clearly understood that mango is generous enough to hold its own with almost anything, and had the good judgment to stop right there.

INSIDE THE GLASS



THE MANGO CHEESECAKE



Cold, dense, and properly buttery where the biscuit base holds everything together, the Mango Cheesecake is the kind of thing you eat slowly because you know it is going to end. The mango on top is generous, bright, and completely serious about itself. One slice is never quite the plan, but it always becomes the reality.

FOR SUGGESTIONS, FEEDBACK OR ADDITIONAL INFORMATION, PLEASE WRITE TO US AT FEATURES@DAILYPIONEER.COM

Although every possible care and caution has been taken to avoid errors or omissions, this publication is being sold on the condition and understanding that information given in this publication is merely for reference and must not be taken as having authority of or binding in any way on the writers, editors, publishers, and printers and sellers who do not owe any responsibility for any damage or loss to any person, a purchaser of this publication or not for the result of any action taken on the basis of this work. All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent court and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only. Readers are advised and requested to verify and seek appropriate advice to satisfy themselves about the veracity of any kind of advertisement before responding to any contents published in this newspaper. The printer, publisher, editor and any employee of the Pioneer Group's will not be held responsible for any kind of claim made by the advertisers of the products & services and shall not be made responsible for any kind of loss, consequences and further product-related damages on such advertisements.

Printed and published by Kushan Mitra for and on behalf of CMYK Printtech Ltd., Regd Office:- 201-205, 208-210, 2nd Floor, Pratap Bhawan 5, B.S.Z. Marg, New Delhi-110002 Phone: 011-46035729, and printed at The Indian Express Ltd., A-8, Sector 7, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) Noida-201 301, Ph: 01202470700. Executive Editor Deepak Kumar Jha. AIR SURCHARGE of ₹ 2.00 East: Calcutta, North: Leh West: Mumbai & Ahmedabad South: Bangalore & Chennai. Central : Khajuraho. Lucknow Office: 4th Floor, Sahara Shopping Centre, Faizabad Road, Lucknow-226 016. Phone:- 9415089265

The Pioneer AGENDA

So I think it's like the night before the exam. Obviously, you stress. But when you have done your job well, then you need to go down, relax and enjoy.
— Andrea Radrizzani



Not So NEET After All

Another NEET paper leak has shattered the faith of lakhs of students who spent years preparing honestly for India's toughest medical entrance exam. This is not just an exam scandal – it is a brutal betrayal of merit, hard work, and the future of an entire generation already battling extreme pressure and uncertainty

NEET: Technology, institutions and top brains failed again

Professor Rajeev Kumar is known as a critical policy whistleblower and the man behind the IIT-JEE reforms. Here, he shares his thoughts on the 2026 National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) cancellations and paper leak

The stakes in medical and engineering admissions in India are extraordinarily high. In a society where family prestige is often tied to the institutions where children study, many parents stretch far beyond their means to secure higher ranks for their wards in these fiercely competitive examinations. Over time, coaching institutes and admission-counseling centers have evolved into a multi-trillion-rupee industry. In such an ecosystem, even cancellations and re-examinations become commercial opportunities, generating fresh demand for crash courses and short-term programs that capitalize on students' stress, desperation, and uncertainty.

For nearly two successive decades, India's two most coveted gateways to professional education - NEET for medical admissions and IIT-JEE for engineering during 2006-2015 - exposed a disturbing pattern. Despite technology, powerful institutions, and the involvement of the finest academic and administrative minds, systemic vulnerabilities repeatedly enabled large-scale admission scams and examination irregularities. From organised paper leaks and impersonation rackets to incorrect cut-offs, wrong questions and answer keys, and allegations of preferential treatment benefiting the wards of the powerful, warning signals were often raised not by institutional safeguards but by whistleblowers facing retaliation. Together, these two eras expose recurring institutional failures, technological overconfidence, and the inability to build transparent, accountable, and robust examination systems.

A factual playbook of institutional failure

This article presents facts repeatedly reported in mainstream media, disclosures obtained under the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, and records placed before the highest offices of the Executive, Judiciary, and other public institutions. With utmost respect for all institutions and stakeholders, the author makes no aspersions against any individual, institution, or beneficiary. Guided by the spirit of "naa kaahu se bair na kahu se dosti" — neither animosity nor closeness toward anyone — the article seeks to present a factual playbook of systemic failures

through two major case studies that together reflect the central theme. At the same time, it carries a strong hope that institutions and those occupying the highest offices of responsibility will move toward genuine accountability instead of merely suppressing issues or blaming small-time operators. Too often, such exercises create the impression that "all is well," while deeper systemic failures, embedded malice, and influential beneficiaries remain buried under the carpet, continuing in their positions without scrutiny or accountability.

Scenario one: Examination day - May 3, 2026

May 3, 2026, was a hectic day for the NTA central control room for two reasons. First, NEET 2026 was conducted across 5,500+ centers in 550 Indian cities and 14 cities abroad, with nearly 2.3 million candidates competing for about 60,000 highly prized government medical seats and many more in private colleges. Second, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, along with the top leadership of the Education Ministry and NTA, was present in the central control room, monitoring live AI-enabled CCTV feeds from thousands of examination halls.

Ironically, the AI-enabled CCTV systems, observers, technical experts, and top officials failed to notice one striking anomaly visible across hundreds of centers — the unusually stress-free confidence, jubilation, and sparkle in the eyes of a large number of candidates appearing for one of the country's most competitive examinations. For many, substantial portions of the paper reportedly appeared already familiar through the widely circulated "guided paper" moving across digital networks days or weeks before the examination. Yet neither the AI-driven surveillance systems nor the country's top institutional minds sensed anything abnormal in this unusually relaxed examination atmosphere.



RAJEEV KUMAR

Scenario Two: Before D-Day - May 3, 2026

After the NEET 2024 fiasco, NTA repeatedly showcased its advanced technologies and stringent security protocols — from encrypted paper-setting and secure PDF transmission for translations to GPS-tracked movement of question papers from bank strongrooms to regional hubs and examination centers. Intelligence and cyber-security inputs from multiple national agencies were also reportedly available. Yet, despite this vast surveillance ecosystem, no alarm appears to have been triggered, while the so-called "guided paper" circulated for weeks across WhatsApp networks in India, alongside large money transactions and growing confidence among candidates and parents that the very questions being practiced would appear in the actual examination.

Scenario Three: After D-Day - May 3, 2026

Immediately after the examination, candidates used to rush to coaching institutes and admission-counseling centers to estimate scores using OMR responses and answer keys, which were widely accessible due to the efforts of a second whistleblower discussed later in this article. Candidates could thus roughly predict their scores, ranks, and chances of securing their colleges of choice. With a significantly large number reportedly answering nearly 135 questions correctly, marks appeared unusually inflated, creating visible jubilation in many circles that the purchase of the "guided paper" had paid off. Yet, despite thousands of observers and an extensive feedback and intelligence network, no unusual pattern appears to have triggered concern within the system.

NEET 2026 Whistleblower: When the system failed

Finally, the first serious alert reportedly came not from the institutional surveillance system but from outside it. A Rajasthan-origin MBBS student studying in Kerala

shared a PDF of a "guess paper" with his father in Sikar, who, with help from a coaching institute, realised that it substantially matched the actual NEET 2026 paper. The first trigger came through a whistleblower message on May 7, followed by a formal complaint to the local police and NTA.

The rest is now familiar - cancellation, re-examination, and immense stress, confusion, and heartbreak for lakhs of students, alongside another business surge for the coaching industry through fresh crash courses. As often happens, investigating agencies may eventually arrest a few small operators and declare the mystery resolved, while the deeper truth behind the alleged high-powered paper-leak mafia and its possible institutional linkages may never surface. Such networks move on to the next examination, while many leaks remain localized and go unnoticed. Similarly, the NEET 2024 fiasco was effectively buried in the 165-page report of the K Radhakrishnan Committee, which left key questions unanswered, including the recurring nature of NEET irregularities year after year.

Exposing IIT Admission Irregularities

Another major whistleblowing development in this ecosystem emerged with the institution of the Right to Information (RTI) framework in 2005. Before the RTI era, most competitive examinations, including medical and engineering entrance tests, operated in near-complete opacity. Candidates were not given question papers, official answer keys, marksheets, or even the selection criteria. In the absence of transparency, people trusted examination agencies almost unquestioningly, and the outcome was merely a "selected" or "not selected," often without any understanding of why. During the RTI era, intervention by late Arjun Singh led IITs to issue marksheets to candidates.

From the beginning, IIT-JEE followed a balanced evaluation model requiring candidates to secure minimum qualifying marks separately in Mathematics, Physics, and Chemistry before aggregate merit was considered. A marked deviation from these subject-wise cut-offs in 2006 triggered whistleblowing by an IIT professor, opening another major chapter in the history of examination irregularities in India.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

Shut the coaching factories down

The ink was barely dry on the NEET-UG answer sheets when the first whispers began. Then came the screenshots, the WhatsApp forwards, the outraged parents, and finally, the staggering admission: the paper had leaked. Millions of students who had spent years — and their families, lakhs of rupees — preparing for a single exam were told, in effect, that the game had been rigged before it began. The government responded swiftly — ordering a CBI investigation, announcing a re-examination, and fast-tracking systemic reforms. But even as accountability was being demanded in the right places, one culpable party continued to escape scrutiny: the vast, lucrative coaching industry that had built an entire economy around gaming the very exam that had just been gamed.

That is the scandal within the scandal. We are debating the leak. We should be debating the ecosystem that made it not just possible, but inevitable.

The coaching industrial complex

India's private coaching industry is worth an estimated ₹58,000 crore and growing. It employs hundreds of thousands of teachers, counsellors, and administrators. It has built entire cities — Kota and Sikar being the few of the most visible — around the singular, grim enterprise of drilling teenagers into rank-producing machines. It promises parents a ladder out of mediocrity and charges them ferociously for the privilege of climbing it. But what it actually sells is access.

Not knowledge. Not skill. Not curiosity or critical thinking. Access — to question banks, to leaked patterns, to insider intelligence about what an exam is likely to test. In a system where a single national test determines the fate of a doctor's career, that access is everything. And it is available, exclusively, to those who can pay for it.

A student from a government school in rural Bihar, however brilliant, is not competing on the same field as a student who has spent two years in a Sikar hostel, taking mock tests every Sunday and being coached by faculty who sometimes have suspiciously accurate foreknowledge of exam trends. This is not a level playing field. It is a field that has been carefully tilted, and then sold back to us as meritocracy.

The paper leak is a symptom

When we trace the NEET paper leak, we follow a trail that almost always winds through the coaching ecosystem — through centers that trade in "sure shot" questions, through networks of middlemen who monetize desperation, through a culture that has normalised, even celebrated, the idea that you don't beat the exam, you game it. The leak did not happen despite the coaching industry. It happened



ROHIT KUMAR SINGH
Former Secretary, Govt of India

because of the culture the coaching industry has normalised: that an exam is a commodity, that a rank can be manufactured, that everything has a price.

There will be those who argue that coaching centers merely respond to demand — that if competitive exams are brutal, someone must prepare students for them. This is the logic of the arms dealer who blames the war. The coaching industry has lobbied, quietly and effectively, against exam reforms that would reduce its relevance. It profits from the very anxiety it stokes. It is not a solution to an unfair system; it is a co-architect of one.

The Government acts: It and must go further

To its credit, the government has moved. The decision to re-conduct the tainted NEET examination is the right call — a necessary act of faith towards the lakhs of honest students who deserved an untainted shot. More significantly, the announcement that the exam will shift to an online, computer-based format from next year is a genuine structural reform. Digital delivery, with randomized question sets, timed server-side encryption, and decentralised testing centers, makes the kind of wholesale physical paper leak we witnessed dramatically harder to execute. This is a good step. It deserves acknowledgment.

But it also raises an uncomfortable question: if we are redesigning the exam to defeat the coaching-center cheat network, why are we leaving the coaching centers themselves standing? The online shift will force them to adapt — and adapt they will, pivoting to "digital mock test" packages and AI-assisted rote drilling, charging even more for the upgrade. The problem is not merely the medium of the paper. The problem is the entire philosophy of preparation that the coaching industry represents. And that philosophy — memorize, repeat, regurgitate, rank — is not just unfair. In the world that these students are about to enter, it is catastrophically useless.

Rote Factories in the Age of AI

Let us be honest about what coaching centers actually teach. They teach pattern recognition of a very specific, very narrow kind. They teach students to identify which formula to apply to which template problem in the least possible time. They reward memory over understanding, speed over reflection, and imitation over inquiry.

CONTINUED ON >> PII



Impact of Trump-Xi Meeting on Canada and India



SURJIT SINGH FLORA
Veteran journalist and freelance writer based in Brampton Canada

Trump's China visit, his first in-person meeting with Xi since Busan in October 2025, come after tariff fights, mineral controls, and seven rounds of talks. Canada and India are not side stories here. Canada faces trade pressure and USMCA stress, while India faces a different test: its strategic weight, manufacturing gains, and energy security.

A softer tone between Washington and Beijing can calm markets. It can also narrow the room that middle powers use to bargain. The meeting matters less for what is announced than for what it tells others about US priorities.

Why the Trump-Xi meeting matters beyond Washington and Beijing

A bilateral summit between the US and China rarely stays bilateral for long. Tariff policy, investor confidence, shipping routes, and security planning all move when the two largest powers change tone.

The current backdrop is fragile. US tariffs on Chinese goods still sit at steep levels, China has pushed back with mineral controls, and both sides want a stable pause more than a grand fix. That kind of pause can ease pressure in the short term. It can also change who gets called first when Washington needs support or when Beijing wants relief. A calmer US-China tone can reduce market stress, but it can also pull US attention toward China and away from allies.

A calmer US - China tone can still shift global power balances

When Washington spends less time containing immediate China risk, it often spends more time managing China directly. That can lower noise in markets, but it can also reduce the urgency behind allied coordination.

For Canada and India, the effect is indirect but real. If the White House feels less pressure from a trade war, it may become more selective with partners. Middle powers then lose some of the attention that comes from great-power tension. In practice, that means less room to press their own concerns at the same time.

Why middle powers feel the impact first Canada and India absorb second-order effects before they see any headline deal. Tariffs shift supply chains. Shipping costs move. Diplomatic talk changes.

Canada depends on the US for about three-quarters of its exports, so any US shift lands fast. India depends on access, investment, and stable energy prices, so its shock comes through factories, fuel, and regional security. Neither country controls the US-China file, yet both pay for the outcome.

What the summit could mean for Canada's economy

Canada enters this moment with limited room to absorb more trade friction. The



The Beijing meeting between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping is unlikely to end the rivalry between the US and China. It can still change the terms around that rivalry

US is still its dominant market, China remains a major trade partner, and Ottawa already faces pressure from tariff disputes and the coming USMCA review.

If Trump and Xi find a workable pause, Washington may feel less need to manage multiple trade fights at once. That can make the climate tougher for Ottawa, because a US administration with fewer urgent fires often becomes more exacting on smaller ones.

USMCA talks could become tougher for Ottawa

A smoother US-China track could give Washington more space to press Canada on familiar pain points. Dairy access, rules of origin, digital policy, and industrial standards all sit on the table.

Canada usually does better when Washington wants speed over detail. If the White House decides its larger strategic fight is elsewhere, Ottawa may face a harder mood and a colder read on concessions. That would matter even if no fresh tariff threat appears.

Canadian exporters could face more competition if China and the US ease tensions

A thaw can also revive Chinese purchases of US farm goods. That would tighten competition for Canadian wheat, canola, and other commodity exports. The pressure would not stop at agriculture. It would also reach metals, machinery, and transport links tied to Asian demand.

If US - China trade flows normalise, Canada loses some of the advantage that came from being a safer fallback supplier. That matters in Asia, where buyers care about price, consistency, and access. A more settled US-China channel can make Canadian goods look less urgent.

Why Canada may need a faster diversification strategy

Ottawa has talked for years about widening trade beyond the US. That talk matters more when the world gets less predictable. Deeper ties with Europe and Asia are not a headline fix. They are a buffer. The point is simple: Canada needs more than one trade lane if it wants less exposure to Washington's shifts.

How India could be affected by a possible US-China reset

India faces a sharper strategic question. Washington has treated New Delhi as a key counterweight to Beijing in the Indo-Pacific. If the US and China lower the temperature, India can lose some of that special status at the margin. That does not erase India's importance. It



does mean the value of that importance can change fast if Trump and Xi reach a practical understanding. India's value as a counterweight to China could be reduced.

A US-China accommodation can create a two-power feel that leaves less room for middle powers. For India, that is the central risk. If Washington and Beijing decide to manage rivalry instead of intensifying it, the US may lean less heavily on India in every diplomatic room. That would matter in defence talks, Indo-Pacific planning, and pressure on Beijing over Taiwan or maritime behaviour. India would still matter, but the urgency around India could soften.

Manufacturing shifts from China may slow down

The China plus One trend has helped pull supply chains toward India. Phone assembly, electronics, and parts production have all benefited from companies wanting backup capacity outside China. A US-China thaw can slow that flow. If tariffs ease or market access improves, some US firms may keep more production in China longer. That would dull the momentum India has gained in manufacturing. It would also sharpen price pressure on Indian factories if Chinese exports surge again.

Border pressure and regional security could become harder to manage

Trade diplomacy does spill into security behavior. If Beijing feels less boxed in by Washington, it may act with more confidence elsewhere. For India, that means the Himalayan border remains a live risk. It does not mean conflict is



TRADE
DIPLOMACY
DOES SPILL
INTO SECURITY
BEHAVIOR.
IF BEIJING
FEELS LESS
BOXED
IN BY
WASHINGTON,
IT MAY ACT
WITH MORE
CONFIDENCE
ELSEWHERE.
FOR INDIA,
THAT MEANS
THE
HIMALAYAN
BORDER
REMAINS
A LIVE RISK



automatic. It does mean a looser US-China deal can leave Beijing with less outside pressure, which can change how it calculates force and timing. New Delhi has already tried to hedge by reopening channels with China, including direct flights and visa easing, while keeping multilateral contact alive through forums like the SCO and BRICS.

Energy prices, currency pressure, and the wider market response

The market reaction may be the most immediate part of this meeting. Oil, metals, shipping, and currency traders all care whether Washington and Beijing settle on clearer rules.

Lower tension usually helps commodity prices become more predictable. That matters for Canada, which relies on resource exports, and for India, which imports most of its energy.

Why lower trade tension can calm commodity markets

When tariff shocks fade, shipping risk often falls with them. That can steady oil and metal prices. For Canada, steadier markets help resource producers plan ahead. For India, they can ease the pressure of a heavy import bill.

A calmer summit does not solve the problem, but it can keep fuel costs from jumping again.

What remains risky for India and Canada even if markets settle?

Stable markets do not erase structural weakness. Canada still depends on the US market more than it should. India still depends on imported energy and on trade routes that can be disrupted by Middle East conflict, including pressure around the Strait of Hormuz.

That is why a summit can look calm on TV while leaving both countries exposed underneath. A lower risk price in markets is not the same thing as real safety. In the End - the Trump-Xi meeting in Beijing is not only a US-China story. It is a test of how much room Canada and India will have in a world shaped by great-power bargaining. Canada faces pressure on trade terms and market access. India faces pressure on strategic relevance, manufacturing gains, and energy security. The biggest effect may not be dramatic at all. It may be a slow tightening or loosening of the space both countries have to act on their own terms.

FROM AGENDA COVER

NEET: Technology, institutions & top...

Before 2006, IIT admission processes operated with near-complete opacity and were allegedly marked by irregularities, irrationalities, and ad hoc practices. In 2006, it emerged that general-category candidates scoring as high as 279 marks were denied admission, while others with only 154 marks were admitted. IITs justified the exclusion by citing unusually high subject-wise cut-offs of [37, 48, 55] in Mathematics, Physics, and Chemistry, though they could not satisfactorily explain how such cut-offs were derived. After a whistleblower challenged the issue, these cut-offs dramatically dropped to single digits - [1, 4, 3] in 2007 and [5, 0, 3] in 2008 out of 182 marks - turning IIT-JEE into a public embarrassment, with even zero marks in Physics making unreserved candidates eligible for IIT admission.

Several other irregularities also surfaced. Errors in questions and answer keys, ambiguous instructions, and procedural loopholes enabled wide-ranging manipulations. Students were admitted to multiple institutions simultaneously, wasting national resources and leaving hundreds of seats vacant, often paving the way for backdoor admissions. Questions were also raised regarding admissions of wards of high-profile IIT professors. At the same time, some professors voluntarily stepped down from influential positions to avoid conflicts of interest when their children appeared for the IIT-JEE.

The Delhi High Court described the situation as "a proverbial situation of it being darkest beneath the lamp," observing that if such facts became widely known, IITs could become "a laughing stock in the eyes of their clients."

IIT-JEE Reforms Through Whistleblowing

The whistleblower's decade-long struggle from 2006-2015, as a single-person army, led to major reforms in IIT admissions through transparency, prior decision-making, and standardized procedures. These included fixing subject-wise cut-offs a priori, allowing candidates to retain question papers, publishing and correcting

answer keys through feedback, providing access to evaluated OMR/ORS sheets before results, pioneering the common engineering entrance framework through JEE (Main), and conceptualizing centralized counseling systems such as JoSAA/CSAB with multiple rounds to optimize seat allocation and prevent blocking of seats.

Most such reforms are in public use across MCQ-based competitive examinations in India, benefiting millions of students annually. Notably, NTA adopted most of these methodologies. Importantly, none of these transparency-oriented SOPs failed in later NEET or JEE controversies; the failures largely arose from logistical and operational vulnerabilities.

The "Unsung Hero" whistleblower

The Supreme Court of India hailed the IIT whistleblower as one of the many "unsung heroes" who helped improve the system and asked IITs to thank the whistleblower appellants for bringing greater transparency and accuracy to the ranking process. IITs did thank him.

Instead, the IIT most exposed by the disclosures subjected the whistleblower to victimization through suspension, institutional marginalization, termination attempts, and endless inquiries. Later, the IIT reportedly passed the baton to another influential IITian who was controlling the whistleblower in a Central University and subsequently headed India's higher-education regulator. The victimization has continued even after retirement, including through the alleged misappropriation of his intellectual contributions.

The way forward

In today's ecosystem, the IIT whistleblower might well have been dismissed, ridiculed, or branded a cockroach for questioning powerful institutions. Yet, the Apex Court recognized that the whistleblower's challenge to the JEE 2006 process, RTI-driven transparency efforts, and the resulting public debate helped make the merit-ranking system more transparent and accurate. The Court further observed that admission



systems must be continuously upgraded. That remains the real way forward for India's high-stakes admission ecosystem. No technology, AI-enabled surveillance, intelligence network, or institutional hierarchy alone can substitute transparency, accountability, continuous process refinement, and the moral courage to acknowledge systemic failures. Institutions do not become weaker by admitting vulnerabilities; they become stronger by correcting them. The real challenge is not merely catching a few paper leaks or small operators after every scandal, but dismantling the deeper ecosystem of opacity, complacency, and institutional protection that allows such crises to recur year after year.

The writer is a Tech Education Policy Consultant, a former Professor of Computer Science at IIT Kharagpur, IIT Kanpur, BITS Pilani, and JNU, and a former scientist at DRDO and DST.

Shut the coaching factories down

In two years of intensive coaching, a student learns to think less, not more - to suppress the inconvenient question, ignore the interesting tangent, and stay ruthlessly on syllabus.

This was always educationally bankrupt. It is now also economically catastrophic.

We are entering an age where artificial intel-

ligence can outperform any coaching-center graduate at the one skill they have spent years perfecting: rote recall and pattern-matched problem solving. An AI can memorise every past NEET paper, identify every recurring question type, and generate ten thousand practice problems before breakfast. If that is all our doctors, engineers, and scientists know how to do, they will be redundant within a decade - not because they failed, but because the system trained them to be replaceable.

Ben Sasse, the American academic and former senator, put it well in a recent essay: the future will be awe-inspiring for those who master the tools of technology, and deeply miserable for those who outsource their thinking and habits to algorithms. The goal, he argues, is to help young people make the most of technology - rather than become a slave to it. Our coaching centers are producing exactly the wrong kind of graduate for this future: young people trained to think like pre-AI computers, drilled in retrieval and imitation, not reasoning and creation. We are, in effect, spending lakhs of rupees to produce minds that a few Rupees worth AI subscription can already outperform.

There is another casualty that rarely gets counted: reading. Coaching centers are notorious for gutting the reading habit. There is no time for books, for wandering curiosity, for the kind of long-form thinking that builds genuine intellect. Yet it is precisely this habit - of deep reading, sustained attention, and intellectual range - that separates a mind capable of navigating the AI age from one that will be consumed by it. A generation that does not read will not lead. It will follow - and eventually, be replaced.

What the AI economy demands I urgently, structurally - is precisely what coaching centers destroy. Creativity. Lateral thinking. Emotional intelligence. The ability to synthesize across disciplines, ask questions that have no textbook answer, and sit comfortably with ambiguity. A doctor who can reason, adapt, and empathize will always be irreplaceable. A doctor optimized purely for MCQ performance is

already being disrupted.

The NEET leak and the online reform together give us a hinge moment. We can tweak the exam and call it a day. Or we can ask what kind of minds we are trying to build - and construct a system worthy of that ambition.

A workable alternative

Every school and college in India already has teachers, classrooms, and infrastructure that sits largely unused after 2 PM. State governments must mandate - and fund - structured remedial and advanced augmenting programs within school premises, free of cost, for students preparing for competitive examinations. These programs, staffed by trained teachers with standardized curricula set by academic bodies, would bring preparation back into the public system - accountable, auditable, and equally accessible.

This is not utopian. Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Kerala have all run successful in-school models that sent thousands of students to IITs and medical colleges without a rupee going to a private coaching baron. The template exists. What is missing is the will to scale it - and the courage to confront a ₹58,000-crore industry that would rather we didn't.

What meritocracy actually requires

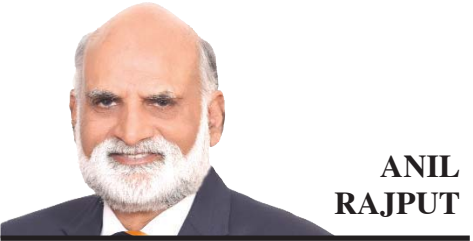
A meritocracy is only legitimate if the race begins from the same starting line. Right now, it does not. A child whose parents can afford years of Kota coaching starts ten metres ahead. That is not merit. That is inheritance wearing merit's clothing.

The NEET leak, the re-examination, the online pivot - all of it has given us a rare window of national attention. Do not waste it on half-measures. Shut the coaching centers. Open the classrooms. Teach children to think, not just to score. The exam of the future will test minds that machines cannot replicate.

Let us build those minds.

The writer is a former Secretary to the Government of India who also served as a Member of the National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission (NCDRC)

The culinary traditions of Rohini Vrat



ANIL
RAJPUT

Rohini Vrat is a significant Jain religious observance associated with spiritual discipline, self-control, fasting and inner purification. Observed primarily within the Jain community, especially among Svetambara traditions, the vrat is linked to the auspicious Rohini Nakshatra in the lunar calendar and is regarded as a path toward spiritual development and ethical living. Over time, the observance has also shaped a distinctive culinary tradition in which food is prepared with great care, simplicity and adherence to the principles of non-violence and purity. The cuisine associated with Rohini Vrat is, therefore, not centred on festivity or opulence but on mindful nourishment, modest consumption and the belief that the manner in which food is prepared and consumed forms an important part of its spiritual character.

The origins of Rohini Vrat are rooted in the wider tradition of vrat, or sacred observances undertaken to cultivate moral and spiritual conduct and detachment from worldly excess. Jain scriptures and later religious commentaries describe such fasts as a means of refining both thought and action, while strengthening the principles of ahimsa and truthfulness. The association of the vrat with the Rohini Nakshatra reflects the importance traditionally given to cosmic timing and auspicious celestial alignments in Indian metaphysical practices. Its continuing significance lies in the way it connects divinity with ordinary acts of living, transforming food from a matter of consumption into an expression of ethical consciousness and mindful living.

Observed by Jain families across the country, Rohini Vrat is linked with devotion to Vasupuiya Bhagwan, the twelfth Tirthankara, who is revered as a symbol of purity, renunciation and victory over worldly attachment. Families across the country may prepare food differently according to regional customs and practices, but the governing ideas remain similar. Ingredients are chosen with care, preparation is kept simple, and food is approached with gratitude. Most households avoid onion, garlic and root vegetables, not only on vrat days but as part of a wider practice shaped by non-violence and sensitivity toward life forms. For strict observers, the timing of food is equally important, with many families avoiding meals after sunset. These practices vary, but the under-

lying spirit remains the same. Food must remain clean, pure and simple. Within this disciplined framework, the savoury foods prepared on the occasion are varied and easy to digest. Sabudana khichdi is one of the most familiar examples from the wider fasting repertoire. Tapioca pearls are washed, soaked until soft and cooked gently with roasted peanuts, a little ghee and mild seasoning. Grated bottle gourd or cucumber is added to preserve softness. Sama rice khichdi and moraiyo pulao offer similar comfort through small millet-like grains that cook quickly and sit lightly on the stomach. They are simmered with cumin, ghee and rock salt and sometimes with bottle gourd or pumpkin. Rajgira roti and singhara atta cheela bring greater substance to the plate without moving away from the fasting idiom. Amaranth flour is patted into soft rotis and cooked on a tawa, while water chestnut flour may be whisked into a batter and prepared as a thin cheela. Farali dhokla, made with vrat-appropriate flours or sama, adds a steamed preparation to the same family of foods. Together, these dishes show how fasting cuisine can be nourishing without becoming heavy.

Vegetable-based preparations give the vrat meal a gentler savoury character, especially when they are cooked without onion, garlic or elaborate masalas. Lauki sabzi is one of the most suitable dishes for such a day. Bottle gourd is peeled, chopped and cooked slowly in its own moisture with ghee, cumin and mild seasoning until it becomes soft and delicate. Pumpkin sabzi brings a natural sweetness that needs little assistance from spice. Its pieces soften over a low flame into a warm, lightly sweet preparation that pairs well with rajgira roti or sama rice. Raw banana curry is also favoured. The bananas, used as a vegetable in the absence of potatoes, are steamed or boiled, peeled and then cooked with cumin, curd, crushed peanuts or coconut. Makhana curry makes for another delectable soft dish where nuts are roasted lightly in ghee and then simmered briefly in a curd-based or milk-based gravy to absorb the flavour. These dishes are not elaborate festive curries but their value lies in the way they offer

“FOOD IS THE MORAL RIGHT OF ALL WHO ARE BORN INTO THIS WORLD”
— NORMAN BORLAUG



satiety without disturbing the reflective mood of the day.

There is also a practical side to fasting food that households uphold. A devotee who has observed the vrat requires nourishment that restores strength but without overwhelming the digestive system. For this reason, preparations such as rajgira thalipeeth, kuttu poori, cucumber peanut koshimbir and simple curd accompaniments may appear in more flexible homes or around parana, the ceremonial breaking of the fast after the completion of the vrat prayers. Rajgira thalipeeth is made by mixing amaranth flour with grated bottle gourd, coriander, cumin and a little curd or water, then patting it on a hot pan until the outside turns lightly crisp. Kuttu poori, prepared from buckwheat flour, is richer and therefore better understood as an occasional post-vrat preparation rather than the central food of the day. Cucumber peanut koshimbir balances such items with freshness. Chopped cucumber is mixed with roasted crushed peanuts, curd and mild seasoning, creating a cooling accompaniment that requires almost no cooking. When these foods are included, their purpose should remain clear. These dishes are meant to help the body reinvigorate from fasting to nourishment.

The sweet side of the Rohini Vrat food culture is also approached with moderation. Makhana kheer and sabudana kheer are among the most popular preparations for their soothing and nourishing nature. Makhana is roasted lightly before being simmered in milk until tender, while sabudana is soaked and cooked slowly until its pearls be c o m e translucent

around them. Cardamom, a little sugar or jaggery, and a few nuts are added, ensuring that the sweetness is kept gentle. Singhara sheera is made by roasting water chestnut flour in ghee until fragrant, then cooking it with warm water or milk until it gathers into a smooth, comforting form. Rajgira laddoo provides sweetness in a compact way, using puffed amaranth bound with warm jaggery syrup. Coconut laddoo and dry fruit paag offer similar nourishment, though they are richer and are taken in small quantities. These sweets complete the meal with care rather than excess. Fruit-based and curd-based sweets bring another dimension to the menu. Shrikhand, made from strained curd mixed with sugar, cardamom and sometimes saffron, is cooling and smooth, yet usually served in modest portions. Fruit chaat may be the simplest and most natural sweet preparation of all. Seasonal fruits such as banana, apple, papaya, pomegranate, grapes and melon are cut fresh and served plain or with the lightest seasoning according to family custom. In many homes, fruits are not treated as secondary items but as central fasting foods because they require little intervention and keep the meal close to nature. Their presence also reflects a larger principle of the vrat. The less the kitchen manipulates food, the closer the devotee remains to simplicity.

Beverages connected with Rohini Vrat and similar fasting observances are equally important because hydration is essential in the warm season. Boiled water has special significance in many Jain households and may be consumed within permitted hours according to family traditions. Tender coconut water gives natural hydration, while lemon sherbet offers freshness when prepared with simplicity and without an overload of sugar. Chaas, made by diluting curd with water and churning it lightly, supports digestion and cools the body while aam panna is prepared from raw mango, and households adapt it according to their recipes and comfort. Sattu sharbat, where accepted, provides strength in a simple form and warm elaichi milk provides another gentle option, especially after a period of fasting. These drinks serve as supportive accompaniments to the simple meals meant to soothe, nourish and refresh.

For Jain monks and nuns, the observance of Rohini Vrat is approached with an even greater degree of spiritual rigor and discipline. Their participation is centred primarily on prayer, meditation, scriptural study and prolonged fasting, reflecting the monastic ideal of detachment from physical comfort and material dependence. Food, when taken, is governed by strict ethical and religious principles. Jain monks traditionally do not cook for themselves or store food, instead accepting limited alms offered by devotees under carefully prescribed conditions intended to minimise harm to living beings and

avoid attachment or desire. Meals are typically simple, sattvic and consumed in small quantities, without indulgence or elaborate preparation. Many avoid eating after sunset entirely, while certain monks may undertake complete fasts during the observance. In this tradition, food is viewed not as pleasure or personal choice, but as a necessity approached with mindfulness, gratitude and spiritual discipline.

Seen in this way, the cuisine around Rohini Vrat reveals a different understanding of food. It is not built around abundance, spectacle or a compulsory festive platter. It is guided by the ethics of selection, preparation, timing and moderation. What is avoided becomes as meaningful as what is prepared. Food is cooked before sunset and consumed within prescribed hours. Ingredients are reduced to the essentials. The meal may consist of fruit, milk, boiled water, a small bowl of khichdi, a soft roti, a cooling accompaniment or a modest sweet at the end of the fast. Each household may observe different practices, but the moral character remains. Food must remain aligned with non-violence and restraint.

Rohini Vrat thus represents a distinct culinary occasion where food is determined by religious guidelines, sunrise, lunar timings or the completion of rituals. It asks the kitchen not to impress but to purify. It reminds us that Indian cuisine is not only the story of elaborate meals, royal dishes, regional delicacies and celebratory abundance but also the story of discipline, fasting, simplicity and ethical nourishment. Within this tradition, a bowl of sama rice khichdi, a piece of rajgira roti, a small serving of makhana kheer or a glass of boiled water can carry as much cultural meaning as a grand feast, because the value lies not in quantity but in intention.

In conserving such observances, I believe we preserve far more than traditional recipes. We preserve a civilisational understanding of food as conduct, where nourishment is guided by compassion and self-command. Rohini Vrat reminds us that cuisine can do more than satisfy the body. It can encourage reflection, discipline desire and inspire morality. At a time when abundance is often celebrated as achievement, this quiet day teaches us that simplicity, when held with faith, can become one of the highest forms of richness. It is therefore our shared responsibility to honour, document and carry forward such traditions, so that future generations inherit not only the taste of Bharat, but also the values that have long given meaning to its food.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)



Tushar Mehta crafts brilliantly bizarre legal wit

ANOOP BOSE

The Bench, the Bar, and the Bizarre: The Unfamiliar, the Curious, and the Extraordinary in Law penned by Tushar (a magnificent name symbolising fine drops of dew and evocative of a sense of purity, calmness and serene winter beauty!) Mehta, the Solicitor General of India, was formally unfurled on May 8, 2026 before a most impressive gathering graced by the venerable Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant and our brave, resolute and visionary Home Minister Amit Anilchandra Shah (who proudly dons the mantle of his lifelong hero and role model Sardar Patel!) and the choicest who's who of political, judicial, and media leaders, whose names read like a veritable roll of honour, within the majestic confines of Bharat Mandapam ensconced deep inside the heart of the Pragati Maidan Complex. The book saw the light of day as a well bound bouquet of amazingly curious, deucedly absurd and helplessly uproarious events from the legal world, aimed at legal professionals and general readers! The chapter on "Judicial Rebels" and "Law beyond the Living" are replete with extraordinary wit and humour. In the chapter on Artificial Intelligence, the author has exoterically summed up the varied challenges posed by AI in an easy, free flowing narration and frankly confessed, "I am neither a technoromantic nor a techno sceptic. But the thought of artificial intelligence entering judicial adjudication — whether through the bench or the Bar is a chilling one. The real danger is not the that machines will start thinking like humans, but that humans will stop thinking like humans and begin to imitate machines".

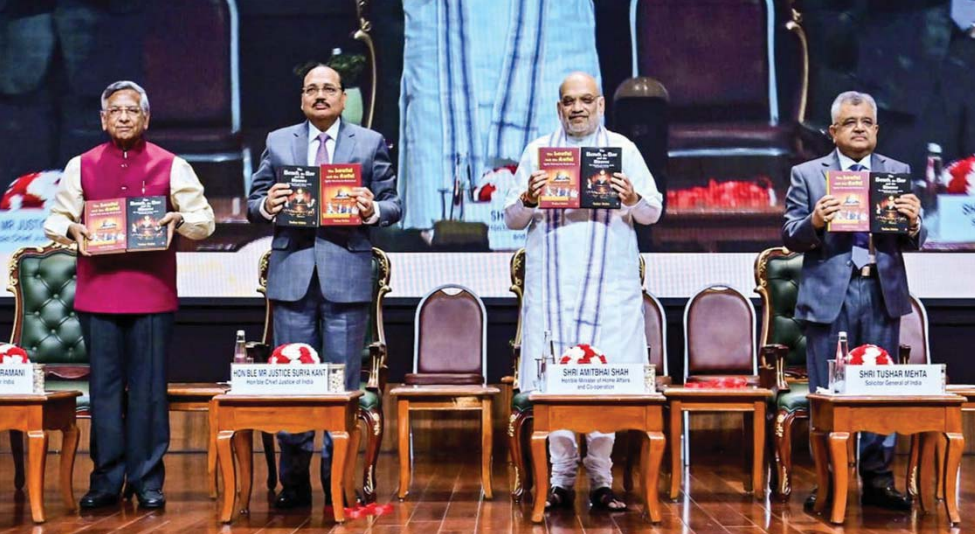
The Lawful and the Awful: Quirky Tales from the World of Law features humorous tales and unexpected moments in law. The most interesting chapters are "Weird Tales of Weirder Judges" and "The Anatomy of a Rotten Judge". The author

in a jocular vein says that there are very good judges and very bad, and even horrible judges. The description on the quality and eminence of several British and American judges is brilliantly explained by him, though he has not touched the Indian judges in the same manner to avoid any untoward controversy or otherwise.

The author dedicated the books to his beloved mother Lataben Mehta on the auspicious occasion of Mother's Day. In his words, he said in a voice choked with emotion that everything he was today was built on his mother's sacrifice and on her continued blessings from heaven. In doing so, he virtually reverberated the timeless words of the monumental lawyer and 16th towering American President Abraham Lincoln, unquestionably the Father of Modern Democracy — "I remember my mother's prayers and they have always followed me. They have clung to me all my life" and "The greatest lessons I have every learned were at my mother's knees... All that I am, or hope to be, I owe to my angel mother".

Tushar's books demonstrate an unusual combination of scholarship, courtroom precision, and literary ease. Unlike many legal writers who rely excessively on technical vocabulary, Tushar explains constitutional questions with clarity, patience, and intellectual confidence. His prose reflects rigorous academic training, yet it never feels burdened by any distracting complexity. Every single chapter reveals a writer who has mastered astute legal reasoning while still respecting the reader's curiosity and attention.

One of the most impressive aspects of his writing is the depth of research. Tushar approaches legal controversies with balance, careful documentation, and analytical sharpness. He connects constitutional theory with contemporary governance in a truly remarkable manner that feels both scholarly and practical. His arguments are persuasive because they are built patiently, layer by layer, rather than through rhetorical



The event was attended by Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Attorney General of India R Venkataramani, Supreme Court and High Court judges, and senior members of the bar, Law Minister of India, Media personalities and the Bhutan delegation.

exaggeration. Readers can sense the discipline of a serious academic mind working behind every observation.

Equally noteworthy is Tushar's refined sense of humour. It is a universally recognized age old proverb that "Laughter is the best medicine" to which I am highly emboldened to add the timeless words of Sir Charles Spencer Chaplin Jr. (popularly known as "Charlie Chaplin"!), the legendary British comic actor, filmmaker, singer, film editor and composer, "A day without laughter is a day wasted." Legal literature often becomes starched and stiff, self-important, and emotionally distant, but Tushar's writing avoids that trap marvellously. He introduces and revels in wit subtly, sometimes through irony, sometimes through understated commentary, and occasionally through

incisively observed anecdotes. These invariably lighten dense discussions without weakening the seriousness of the subject. The humour feels intelligent rather than performative, making difficult themes more engaging and memorable.

Ultimately, Tushar succeeds not only as a legal thinker but also as a communicator of rare effectiveness. His books enrich public discourse because they combine academic brilliance with readability, authority with accessibility, and seriousness with warmth. They deserve appreciation from lawyers, students, policymakers, and general readers alike. In an era lamentably marked by intellectual writing frequently becoming either excessively simplified or unbearably dense, Tushar's work achieves an admirable balance between scholarship, persuasion, and

humane expression.

Tushar has by his well honed literary skills, nay prowess, proved beyond a shadow of doubt for all the world to see that the pen can be infinitely mightier than the black gown (signifying submission to the law!) and the twin white bands (signifying the Tablets of Law!) that can be traced back to the 17th Century British tradition that refuses to set eternally at a global level! I need hardly add that no word of praise from a lesser mortal like me can embellish the praise and acclaim he has well justifiably earned from near and far for his twin literary offering. His powerful voice remains thoughtful, disciplined, and surprisingly conversational, qualities that ensure his arguments continue resonating beyond the trappings of academia and courtrooms. The author has deliberated upon and narrated the critical aspects of the judicial system by drawing upon the American and British systems and has scrupulously avoided critical aspects of the Indian judicial system. This may disappoint the Indian reader, but the intelligent reader with insightful information on the Indian judiciary can draw clear references where the author wants to strike. The contents of the books have an international appeal, and surely, Tushar must be having plans to launch his books on American and British soil in the very near future.

In conclusion, I am irresistibly drawn to the words of George Bernard Shaw — **"You don't stop laughing when you grow old, you grow old when you stop laughing."**

May ever smiling, always hospitable Tushar Mehta continue to tirelessly strive to write, guide and inspire generations of lawyers, judges and erring ones to come! And may God Almighty bless his scholarship, wisdom, erudition, literary skills and legal acumen always!

(The writer is an avid debater, public speaker, writer, broadcaster, telecaster, artist, painter, sculptor, music critic and filmmaker)

When Everything Appears Meaningless

The world is changing. The Self is unchanging. Only in wisdom can one be enthusiastic amidst uncertainty. Often, uncertain people do not act; they simply sit and wait. Acting in uncertainty makes life a game

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

When everything appears meaningless, only then do you seek meaning. If everything is already meaningful, then the journey stops right there. There is no journey at all, no question of even stopping. When there is no quest, there is no journey at all. The quest that begins with questions like “What is this?” or “Who am I?” is very important in the spiritual realm. In fact, this is the first step in the spiritual realm, where you find everything else meaningless, and you want to find meaning.

Let this sense of emptiness go deep. Sink into it. Don't be in a hurry to find the answers. When a seed sprouts, it grows into a little sapling; don't be in a hurry to cut it, assuming that it has become a tree. Let it grow into a huge tree. Then you can sit under it. Once the tree has grown, even if you prune the leaves or some of its branches, it will benefit you. But don't cut a sapling that has just sprouted. Keep pondering the question, ‘Who am I?’ Don't be in a hurry to conclude. Stay relaxed and let go. You will start going deeper into meditation if you just stay with this question.

Once you understand that everything else is meaningless, then the next question that comes up is: What is truly meaningful? What is worth knowing? What is the purpose of creation? Why did God create this earth? These questions, in a very significant manner, begin your inward journey.

That is why a real teacher will not give you an answer to this, though he knows it. Know that you are fortunate that this question arose within you. And, you are in the right place where you will find the answer. When you are on the spiritual path, you'll find the answer.

Recently, a Bollywood casting director who was in our ashram for the 45 years of The Art of Living asked me why some successful people still felt empty within. I said, “They are lucky!” When they feel emptiness within, their real search begins. They realise that life isn't only about position, money, and fame. One should welcome and embrace this feeling of emptiness because it leads them towards the main purpose of life.

When you look within and find emptiness, instead of running away from it, shake hands with it. You change your jobs, or change your partners — you do everything to fill up that sense of void. All you need to do is wake up and see — your background is emptiness, your foreground is also emptiness. Deep in your heart, there is emptiness. Shake hands with it. Be strong and steady in it. Then, you will see that misery and sorrow will evaporate. You will realise that you yourself are love. You are what you are seeking.

How do you feel when you experience something? You'll find that the completion of an experience leads to void or nothingness. In the progression of life, you will leave behind every experience, saying, ‘This is nothing.’ Anything that is completed loses its importance. That is to say, it leads you to void — the feeling of ‘this is nothing’. A sign of intelligence is how soon you arrive at this understanding. Examine everything in life and say, ‘This is nothing’, and what remains after all that is ‘Love’, and that is everything.

When the realisation of ‘This is nothing’ doesn't come out of knowledge, it comes out of misery. Either through knowledge



“WHEN YOU LOOK WITHIN AND FIND EMPTINESS, INSTEAD OF RUNNING AWAY FROM IT, SHAKE HANDS WITH IT”
— GURUDEV



ONCE YOU UNDERSTAND THAT EVERYTHING ELSE IS MEANINGLESS, THEN THE NEXT QUESTION THAT COMES UP IS: WHAT IS TRULY MEANINGFUL? WHAT IS WORTH KNOWING? WHAT IS THE PURPOSE OF CREATION? WHY DID GOD CREATE THIS EARTH? THESE QUESTIONS, IN A VERY SIGNIFICANT MANNER, BEGIN YOUR INWARD JOURNEY

or through misery, you come to the point of ‘This is nothing’. The choice of how you come to that point is yours.

I want you to realise one thing. Wake up and see: till this moment, whatever has happened in your life for the last 30 to 50 years, is it not like a dream? Take your mind forward and backward in time. You are sitting here and reading this article. Tomorrow you will wake up, brush your teeth, and get on with your work. The next day will roll on, then June will arrive, and so will August and

September, and before you know it, you will be having a New Year's party. It will all be gone! Is it not like a dream? Couldn't this moment be a dream too? Is this moment real? How do you know it is reality? The future is like a dream, the past is anyway a dream, and this moment that is passing by can also be a dream, can it not? If you can manage to shift your attention and see this reality, you will see something beyond what meets the eye. There is a higher truth beyond this, which is so beautiful. And if you see this, you gain such incredible strength, energy, love, and beauty in your life that nothing whatsoever will be able to snatch your smile away. Immediately, you get connected to the universal power, to the truth that you are made up of.

There is a clear distinction between practical and spiritual life. When you have to work with people, don't use this philosophy, ie, don't think that everything is nothing. You will not be able to do your business or your work. However, keep this in mind — everything is nothing. This gives you inner strength, intuitive ability, happiness, contentment, love, and compassion. As you grow more in wisdom and see the changing, dream-like nature of events, you will be touched by events less and less. Know that life is a dream and everything will come to an end. With this knowledge, the mind becomes pleasant, and the intellect becomes sharp.

Uncertainty seems frightening only when you rely on what cannot be relied upon, which is the relative world. People often try to hold on to things that are changing, and when those shift, anxiety and fear follow. But when you anchor yourself in that which does not change — the Self — then you can sail through even the most uncertain times. The only way you can be at ease with the uncertainty of the world is when you realise the certainty of consciousness.

The world is changing. The Self is unchanging. Only in wisdom can one be enthusiastic amidst uncertainty. Often, uncertain people do not act; they simply sit and wait. Acting in uncertainty makes life a game. A readiness to face uncertainty, coupled with awareness, takes you to a higher state of consciousness, where no one can take your smile away.

Home Sweet Home

In an age overwhelmed by digital distractions and widening generational divides, the warmth of many homes is quietly fading into silence, misunderstanding, and emotional distance. To heal this growing crisis, Pramukh Swami Maharaj offered humanity a timeless and transformative gift — *Gharsabha*, 'the sacred family assembly'. More than a ritual, it is a powerful forum for dialogue, reflection, and spiritual bonding that has helped countless families overcome years of tension, conflict, and estrangement. By nurturing understanding between generations, Gharsabha transforms homes into sanctuaries of respect, harmony, and heartfelt connection. In a fractured world searching for unity, this simple yet profound practice may hold the key to restoring the soul of the family



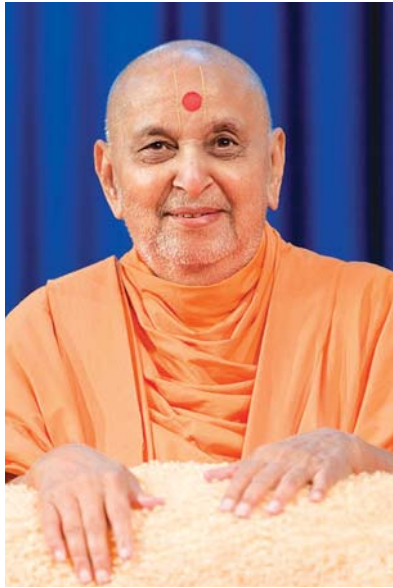
DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

Does the word in the title sound familiar? This word, ‘Home Sweet Home’, is a phrase we often use, but the real question is: If instead of celebrating delightful Diwali, we are always celebrating Holi of quarrels, and instead of sweet speech, the acid of insults and accusations is poured upon one another, should we still call it a home, or a raging battlefield?

In our society, there is a beautiful tradition of giving names to houses. But how ironic it is! A house named *Satkar* (respect) often resounds with *Dhutkar* (insults). In a home called *Ullas* (joy), people may live in sorrow. A flat called *Leelalaher* (playful waves) might feel like poison to its residents. Even in a bungalow named *Harsh* (laughter), terror may dwell, and in a row house named *Shanti* (peace), unrest may prevail. Can such houses truly be called homes? Or are they merely lifeless walls? A house is built with bricks and beams, but a home is built with love and dreams. Without affection, forgiveness, and harmony, even a palace feels like a prison; with them, even a hut becomes heaven.

However, today, in every home, you will find tea sets, dinner sets, sofa sets, TV sets, all kinds of “sets.” But if the people living inside are constantly “upset,” then can we really call it a home? Everyone dreams of building the house of their dreams, a place filled with love, harmony, and warmth. Yet, where there are people, there are bound to be differences, jealousy, ambition, and ego. Despite a deep connection, not every family becomes the ideal home they imagined. This dilemma is not new. But now, how can we make our home sweet?

Pramukh Swami Maharaj had offered the remedy to make our home sweet. He gave the practical concept of *Gharsabha*. *Gharsabha* encourages family members to gather daily to discuss satsang concepts and share updates and happenings from each other's lives. This daily dose of communication gives spouses, parents and children a better understanding of each other's spiritual, physical, and emotional needs. Pramukh Swami Maharaj deeply



BY NURTURING UNDERSTANDING BETWEEN GENERATIONS, GHARSABHA TRANSFORMS HOMES INTO SANCTUARIES OF RESPECT, HARMONY, AND HEARTFELT CONNECTION. IN A FRACTURED WORLD SEARCHING FOR UNITY, THIS SIMPLE YET PROFOUND PRACTICE MAY HOLD THE KEY TO RESTORING THE SOUL OF THE FAMILY

understood the fragile dynamics of family life. He foresaw that when agitation, misunderstanding, and silent resentment begin to enter a home, they slowly erect invisible walls between hearts.

With time, those walls grow stronger, turning affection into distance and conversation into silence. Therefore, he emphasised that the first step toward restoring harmony is to break this wall of silence and misconception. This is precisely how *Gharsabha* works. It gently dissolves the barricades of conflict and reopens the pathways of communication within the family. Through the shared

reading of sacred *shastras*, thoughtful reflection, and heartfelt dialogue, even a few simple words begin to rekindle warmth between family members. Gradually, conversations replace confrontation, understanding overcomes suspicion, and affection begins to flow once again. *Gharsabha* does not merely ignite the spark of love; it carefully nurtures and sustains it, transforming the home into a sanctuary of trust, unity, and spiritual closeness.

This timeless wisdom shows us the essence of happy family life: No matter what attitude someone has towards me, I should always strive to see the good in them.

Shaileshbhai Dhanani of Rajkot relates his experience, “Sometime after my marriage, troubles started between my wife and me. I worked in a factory. Sometimes, due to an overload of work, I used to come home late. As a result, my wife became suspicious of me and this led to heated arguments and increasing conflicts. My parents became fed up with her bickering, hollow suspicions and unfounded accusations. I found my life hellish and our relationship came to the point of breaking up. One day, the conflict climaxed to such a point that my exasperated wife attempted suicide. But she was saved because of Vinubhai, our landlord, who came and calmed her.”

Thereafter, Shaileshbhai witnessed the *Gharsabha* carried out at Vinubhai's house next door and the resulting joy and ease in their family. He was inspired and started *Gharsabha* in his home. Shaileshbhai adds, “In the beginning, I used to do *Gharsabha* on my own. My wife ignored it, but gradually, all the members joined me. Slowly, my wife became interested in *satsang*. She started to sit at some distance and gradually came closer. Our differences started to dissolve and our problems were solved. Finally, there was peace and joy between us.”

In this way, *Gharsabha* mended a broken family with trust and love.

(The writer Dr Sadhu Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

Weekly Overview

The week begins with the Moon in Taurus, supporting steadiness, comfort and practical thinking. As it moves into Gemini, communication and activity increase. Midweek, the Cancer Moon heightens emotional sensitivity and family concerns. By the weekend, the Moon enters Leo, bringing stronger confidence, visibility and a desire for action.



Aries (Mesh): The week begins on a practical note, especially in work or financial matters, where steadiness will help more than speed. As the Moon moves into Gemini, conversations and pending plans gain momentum. Midweek, emotional sensitivity may rise in domestic or close matters, so avoid quick reactions. By the weekend, confidence returns and your natural urge to move ahead becomes stronger. A balanced approach will serve you well.



Taurus (Vrishabh): With the Moon beginning the week in your own sign, you may feel more centred and engaged with matters around you. This is a supportive start, though comfort should not turn into stubbornness. Midweek may bring emotional sensitivity in communication, and words spoken in haste could create misunderstandings. By the weekend, confidence improves and practical matters move with greater clarity. A calm and steady approach will work best.



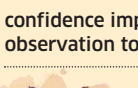
Gemini (Mithun): The opening days may feel quieter, with matters moving more in the background. Once the Moon enters Gemini, your pace naturally increases, bringing sharper thinking, movement and useful conversations. Midweek, emotional shifts may make practical decisions less straightforward, especially in family matters. Financial decisions should be handled carefully. By the weekend,

WEEKLY MOON SIGN FORECAST | 17-23 MAY

Steady Beginnings, Emotional Undercurrents

Dr. Shanker Adawal
Astrologer, Author & Researcher

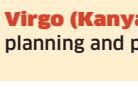
This forecast is based on your Moon Sign (Janma Rashi), which often reflects day-to-day emotional and instinctive patterns more closely than general Sun-sign readings.



Cancer (Karka): The early part of the week may feel socially active yet mentally scattered, with several matters competing for attention. Once the Moon enters Cancer, emotional awareness becomes stronger, increasing both sensitivity and intuition. The key is not to let mood drive important decisions. Domestic or relationship matters may need patience and softer handling. Toward the weekend, confidence rises and your focus shifts from reflection toward action.



Leo (Simha): The week begins with a practical and duty-oriented tone, especially in professional matters where patience will work better than dramatic action. Midweek may bring changing plans or communication demands requiring flexibility. As emotional energy rises, you may feel more reflective than usual. By the weekend, the Moon enters Leo, restoring confidence and visibility. This closing phase supports leadership and initiative, provided ego does not overtake judgment.



Virgo (Kanya): The week opens constructively, favouring planning and practical progress. Professional discussions may

confidence improves. This is a week of moving from inward observation to outward action.



prove useful. As the Moon moves into Gemini, responsibilities and communication demands may increase. Midweek brings a softer emotional current, where friendships or expectations may affect your mood more than expected. Avoid overanalysing unclear situations. By the weekend, confidence improves and perspective becomes stronger. Quiet discipline will help more than emotional involvement.



Libra (Tula): The early week supports practical assessment, especially around commitments or shared responsibilities. Communication improves as the week progresses, bringing movement in plans or professional matters. However, during the Cancer phase, you may feel more sensitive to others' responses, especially in public or work settings. Avoid reading too much into temporary situations. By the weekend, confidence improves and support from others may feel stronger.



Scorpio (Vrishchik): This week begins with focus on partnerships or close interpersonal matters, where patience will be important. As the Moon moves into Gemini, financial or practical concerns may need clearer handling. Midweek brings a more emotionally supportive phase, strengthening intuition and perspective. This can be a useful time for reflection or reconnecting with meaningful priorities. By the weekend, external responsibilities may again demand stronger attention.



Sagittarius (Dhanu): The week begins with focus on routine matters, responsibilities and work structure. Progress may feel slow, but useful movement is possible. As the Moon enters

Gemini, relationships and communication become more central. Midweek emotional undercurrents may make exchanges feel heavier than expected, so avoid quick conclusions. By the weekend, confidence and optimism return. This closing phase supports movement, learning and broader thinking.



Capricorn (Makar): The opening phase is supportive, with practical matters moving steadily. This can be a useful time for planning or stabilising pending concerns. Midweek, communication and responsibilities may increase. Emotional sensitivity in close relationships may require patience rather than control. By the weekend, confidence returns and practical clarity improves. Overall, this remains a constructive week, provided emotional reactions stay measured.



Aquarius (Kumbh): The week begins with attention drawn toward home, family matters or emotional comfort. Midweek brings stronger communication, movement and planning. As emotional sensitivity increases, routine matters may feel heavier, especially if others depend more on your support. Maintain practical boundaries. By the weekend, focus shifts toward relationships and outward engagement. This phase may bring greater visibility, but patience will still be important.



Pisces (Meen): The opening days support communication, movement and practical engagement with day-to-day matters. Midweek supports mental activity, though emotional clarity may fluctuate. As the Moon enters Cancer, intuition and emotional expression become stronger. Creative thinking improves, though practical decisions still require care. By the weekend, focus shifts back toward routine responsibilities and structure. This is a week where intuition helps, but discipline remains equally important.